



INDIA'S PRIDE

Elavenil & Co. open Nagoya account

SPORT » PAGE 16



CAMPUS POLITICS

Minister promises talks on Kerala varsity rules

STATES » PAGE 3

DATA POINT

The paradox of self-reliance

China-centric supply chains create an 'assembly trap' for India

OPINION » PAGE 9



'WEAK-KNEED GOVT.'

100% U.S. tariffs will hit India badly: Cong.

NEWS » PAGE 5

INSIDE



U.S. is aware of terms to open Hormuz: Iran

TEHRAN

Iran's top negotiator Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf said on Sunday that Tehran had conveyed to Washington through mediators its conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Tehran maintains a stranglehold on the shipping route since the U.S-Israeli strikes on Iran began in late February. » PAGE 14

Advani, top poll official on SIR list for EC notices

NEW DELHI

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, senior BJP leader L.K. Advani, Election Commissioner Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and former Delhi Deputy Chief Minister Manish Sisodia were among several prominent names on Delhi's draft voters roll to be identified for Election Commission (EC) notices under special intensive revision (SIR). » PAGE 4

Kurmis will be exempt from UCC: Suvendu

KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday said the Kurmi community would be kept outside the ambit of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC). He also announced that cases registered against members of the community during protests under the previous Trinamool Congress government would be withdrawn. » PAGE 5

'151 Ambedkar statues across U.P. vandalised'

LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday alleged that 151 statues of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar had been vandalised across 72 districts of Uttar Pradesh, during the BJP's nine-and-a-half-year rule. It was a deliberate attempt to humiliate marginalised social groups and followers of B.R. Ambedkar, he said. » PAGE 5

5 militants killed, hostages rescued in Balochistan

ISLAMABAD

Pakistani security forces killed five militants in a shootout and freed 23 hostages in the country's restive southwest province of Balochistan, the military said on Sunday. The militants had set up an illegal checkpoint near Kalat, stopping vehicles to abduct more people for ransom, extort money and seize vehicles, it said. » PAGE 14

Tata Sons fell short of AoA conditions: Trusts

Chandrasekaran reappointment invalid, it says, challenging the casting vote mandate on Sept. 17

Trusts insists that chairman's vote which led to the approval of resolutions, had no *locus standi*

Says resolution lacked majority support from Tata Trusts-nominated directors as mandated

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Tata Trusts, the majority owner of Tata Sons, has challenged the validity of the holding company's September 17 decision to reappoint N. Chandrasekaran as the chairman of its Board, arguing that its Articles of Association (AoA) require affirmative support from both its Trust-nominated directors. A chairman's casting – or tie-breaking – vote cannot override that condition, Tata Trusts said.

In a statement issued on Sunday, Tata Trusts, the philanthropic body which has a majority ownership of the company, also denied the existence of any deadlock at the Tata Sons Board meeting on September 17. It insisted that the casting vote by the chairman of the meeting, independent director Harish Manwani, which led to the Board approving two crucial resolutions, had no *locus standi*.

The AoA “do not leave

any decision of the Board to a mere head count of directors. They provide that no decision can be taken unless it has the affirmative support of at least a majority of the directors nominated by the Tata Trusts, who hold approximately 66% of the company,” Tata Trusts said.

Two directors' votes

Stating that this was a separate condition under the AoA, the Tata Trusts said, “There are two Tata Trusts nominees on the Board of Tata Sons [Venu Srinivasan and Noel Naval Tata]. Majority amongst two is two and not one.”

“On September 17, 2026, one such director [Noel Naval Tata] voted against the resolution. Thus, the affirmative support of Tata Trusts nominee directors as mandated by the AoA was not given. The condition failed, and so did the resolution,” Tata Trusts emphasised. It also denied any paralysis or deadlock arising from the “refusal of support” by Mr. Tata which would have entitled

Power dynamics

Tata Trusts has detailed provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons to challenge the reappointment of Chandrasekaran

What the majority owner says

■ As per the AoA, any decision will need affirmative support of a majority of directors nominated by it

■ There are currently two directors, Venu Srinivasan and Noel Naval Tata, nominated by Tata Trusts, and a majority will need both their votes

■ While Mr. Srinivasan voted for the resolution on the chairperson, Mr. Tata voted against it, failing the AoA condition and the resolution



Noel Naval Tata

■ Casting vote is available only where there is equality of votes at the overall Board level, which was absent here

the chairman of the meeting to have a casting vote.

Pointing out that the chairman's casting vote is available only where there is equality of votes at the overall board level, the Tata Trusts said it does not apply amongst Tata Trusts' nominee directors. “Whether the result of the vote was 4:1, or any other figure, is irrelevant. A condition is either met, or it is not. In this case the condition was not met,” it stated.

“On the suggestion that a refusal of support [by nominee director Mr. Tata]

amounted to a deadlock which would paralyse the Company and that the Chairman of the meeting was therefore entitled to resolve the position by a casting vote, there was no paralysis and there was no deadlock,” it reiterated.

“The Board put a question, and the AoA answered it in the negative. The exercise of a protective right conferred by a company's own constitution is not a deadlock; it is that constitution working as it was written to work,” Tata Trusts said.

According to Tata Trusts, the resolution to reappoint N. Chandrasekaran as the chairman of Tata Sons, considered at the Board meeting on September 17, was not validly passed and has no legal effect.

“In the eyes of the law, it is void *ab initio* [from the beginning],” it reiterated.

Mistry proceedings

Stating that the Articles of Association are not a convenience to be relied upon when they help and ignored when they don't, Tata Trusts said, “Tata Sons is not at liberty to take this position, because it has already taken the opposite one and won in the Supreme Court.”

In the proceedings arising out of the removal of former Tata Sons chairman Cyrus Mistry, the affirmative voting rights of the Trusts' nominee directors under Articles 104B and 121 were squarely in issue, it said.

“The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal held them to be oppres-

sive, and the complainants [Mistry & his SP Group Co] asked that they be deleted or confined. Tata Sons resisted that attempt. It defended these rights as a legitimate protection agreed between the shareholders, and it argued that far from being oppressive they were in truth the Trusts' entitlement as a majority shareholder,” it pointed out.

In 2020, the Supreme Court of India had accepted Tata Sons' case and set aside the finding that these Articles were oppressive.

“The Company cannot now disown the protection it went to the Supreme Court to preserve. They are either in the Articles or they are not. Tata Sons has already told the highest court in the country that they are,” it said.

“It is unfortunate that the Chairman [Mr. Chandrasekaran] of Tata Sons, a Company renowned for setting high standards of corporate governance, is contending reappointment on such an untenable interpretation of the Arti-

cles,” it stated.

To the suggestion that listing will bring enhanced corporate governance, Tata Trusts said the argument of a governance gap does not exist. “Pulling apart a hundred-year-old structure to fill an imaginary gap is taking a sledgehammer to crack a nut,” it said.

“Independently of listing, Tata Sons has for years chosen to hold itself to the standards of a public company. Its own AoA contain provisions applicable to public companies, including the appointment of independent directors, the constitution of an audit committee and a nomination and remuneration committee, provisions governing related party transactions and the retirement of directors by rotation, together with a code of conduct for the prevention of insider trading,” Tata Trusts noted.

It said this was done voluntarily, for reasons of transparency and governance, and long before any of the present questions arose.

Guardians assemble



Chief of the Air Staff Air Chief Marshal A. P. Singh (L) and Chief of Staff Japan Air Self-Defense Force General Takehiro Morita during Exercise Veer Guardian 26 at Air Force Station Jodhpur in Rajasthan. PTI [REPORT ON PAGE 4]

SC calls for law to guard multi-crore court deposits

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A law is necessary to protect crores deposited by litigants across courts and tribunals in the country during pending appeals, the Supreme Court said in a recent judgment.

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe observed that litigants' money should be saved from ad-hoc management while calling for nationwide legislative reform to standardise how courts and tribunals handle the money.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 6

Nepal keen to reset India ties: Minister

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

A month after the devastating Bhotekoshi floods, Nepal Prime Minister Balen Shah will visit New York next week to address the UN General Assembly and discuss the country's recovery plans, Nepal's Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle has said.

He also confirmed that Mr. Shah's first bilateral visit would be to India later this year, and that the new government was keen to “reset” ties and move away from “jingoism” over sovereignty issues and the border dispute that has led to tensions in the past.

“The old era of jingoism and equating Nepali na-



Swarnim Wagle

tionalism with anti-Indianism is over,” Mr. Wagle said in an interview to *The Hindu* on Saturday.

Mr. Wagle said his talks with Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar centred on the flood recovery plan.

INTERVIEW ON
» PAGE 5

Ukrainians launch their largest drone attack on Moscow

Agence France-Presse
MOSCOW

Ukraine fired waves of drones at Moscow and the surrounding region early on Sunday, killing two people and setting an oil refinery ablaze as Russians voted in the third and final day of parliamentary elections, officials said.

The attack was the largest on Moscow since the Kremlin launched its Ukraine offensive in 2022 and involved some 1,600 drones, 450 of which were aimed directly at the capital, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said.

The Moscow Mayor accused Ukraine of attempting to interfere with the

elections that are widely expected to result in another win for the ruling United Russia party which backs President Vladimir Putin. “The unprecedented attack was clearly planned with the aim of disrupting the elections. The enemy did not succeed,” Mr. Sobyanin said on Telegram.

Significant impact

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy praised the strikes, saying: “Our long-range responses had a very significant impact in the Moscow region last night.”

“One of Russia's key oil industry facilities and the aggressor's logistics facility



Capital strike: Smoke rises at an oil refinery following Ukrainian drone strikes in Moscow on Sunday. REUTERS

were hit. These are billions of dollars that sustain the war machine,” he posted on X.

At least two people were killed in Sunday's attacks – a 44-year-old woman and

an elderly man – in two separate locations, Moscow regional Governor Andrey Vorobyov said.

A fire triggered by a drone crashing into a 21-storey building also led to

400 people being evacuated, Mr. Vorobyov said.

The parliamentary vote is Russia's first since launching its Ukraine offensive in 2022, and while the results are unlikely to offer many surprises, they may offer clues as to public sentiment towards the war. Putin had urged Russians to take part, casting the vote as a show of support for Moscow's troops and an “answer to those who want to weaken Russia”.

Meanwhile, Russia's electoral chief said there had been a wave of cyberattacks targeting election infrastructure.

Ella Pamfilova, chair of Russia's Central Election

Commission, did not say who was responsible.

The attacks appeared to have been carried out by “highly professional, well-coordinated groups using artificial intelligence tools,” she said.

Four killed in Kyiv

A Russian strike in Ukraine's Kyiv region killed at least four people, three of them children, the Ukrainian authorities said on Sunday.

The attack late on Saturday also damaged 31 sites, including apartment buildings, according to the regional Governor.

Russian strikes also targeted the railways in central Ukraine on Sunday.

Tejashwi flays NDA govt. in Bihar on flood relief efforts

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Assembly Tejashwi Yadav on Sunday criticised the NDA government over flood relief efforts in the State and the money spent on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday celebrations. He called Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and B national president Nitin Nabin “rubber stamps”.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 5

INBRIEF



Prashant Kishor announces 5 names for Bihar Council polls

Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) founder and Bankipur MLA Prashant Kishor on Sunday announced five candidates for the upcoming Bihar Legislative Council polls. The JSP has decided to field Divya Jyoti, S.P. Rai and Afaq Ahmed from Patna, Darbhanga and Saran teachers' constituencies, respectively. Ravindra Yadav and Rajnish Ranjan will contest from Darbhanga and Kosi graduate constituencies. Candidates for the remaining three constituencies will be announced soon. The terms of the eight members of the Legislative Council are due to expire on November 16.

Rajasthan SI 2021 recruitment retest held across 11 districts

The Rajasthan Police Sub-Inspector and Platoon Commander Recruitment Re-examination 2021 was held across 11 districts on Sunday amid tight security, officials said. A total of 2,18,114 candidates registered for the re-examination, which was conducted at 666 centres. Candidates underwent biometric verification, facial recognition and frisking before being allowed to enter the examination centres to prevent malpractices. The re-examination was conducted four years after the recruitment examination was cancelled following a paper leak. PTI

Mahanadi water dispute will be resolved soon: Chhattisgarh CM

Press Trust of India
BHUBANESWAR

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Sunday said the Mahanadi water dispute with Odisha is likely to be resolved "very soon", asserting that both States have agreed to accept the decision of the Centre on the matter.

Mr. Sai, on a two-day visit to Odisha, said the issue would be resolved because there are BJP governments in Chhattisgarh and Odisha and an NDA government at

the Centre.

"Both of us (Chief Ministers) have given consent to the Centre that we will accept whatever decision is taken by the Central Water Commission with regard to the Mahanadi issue," he said. Mr. Sai later met Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi in the city.

In a social media post, Mr. Majhi wrote that he had a "fruitful interaction" with his counterpart on strengthening cooperation between the two States, and advancing their shared

commitment towards the welfare of people.

Mr. Sai's remarks, particularly his assertion that there was no longer a dispute over Mahanadi water distribution, drew criticism from the Opposition Biju Janata Dal, which questioned whether Odisha's interests were being protected. "The Chhattisgarh government is the creator of the Mahanadi water dispute. The statement of its CM that it is not a dispute is unacceptable," said the party.

Gave jobs to 9.5 lakh, letters to 1 lakh more soon, says U.P. CM; joblessness rampant: Akhilesh

Recruitments have been transparent, merit-based under State govt.: Adityanath; people aggrieved, SP will cut BJP's votes in every constituency by 27,000 in Assembly election, says Oppn. party chief

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday criticised the Opposition over alleged irregularities, nepotism and corruption in recruitment, saying those who had turned Uttar Pradesh 'BIMARU' (sick) had no right to question the present government's record.

He said over 9.5 lakh youth had been given opportunities to serve in the State government since 2017 and announced that another 1 lakh would receive appointment letters within the next six months.

The acronym 'BIMARU' was coined in the mid-1980s, based on the names of the then poorest States - Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and U.P.

Samajwadi Party (SP) chief and former CM Akhilesh Yadav hit back at Mr. Adityanath, claiming, "The youth is facing large-scale unemployment. There are



U.P. CM Yogi Adityanath taking a selfie at a programme in Lucknow; SP president Akhilesh Yadav briefing the media on Sunday. ANI/ PTI

no government jobs, and even where such jobs did exist, their rights have been systematically snatched away. Reservation has been snatched."

He added that his party has set a goal of reducing the BJP's votes by 27,000 in every Assembly seat.

The U.P. Assembly is set to go to the polls next year.

'No more paper leaks'

Speaking at an event in Lucknow, the CM said the recruitment process before 2017 was marred by

recommendations, illegal transactions, paper leaks and discrimination.

He asserted that the BJP-led government, which came to power after the 2017 election, had made recruitment transparent and merit-based.

"Those who, through their inaction and inability, turned Uttar Pradesh into a BIMARU State have no right to speak about U.P. Police or the administration of Uttar Pradesh," he said, speaking after distributing appointment letters

Mann launches AAP's door-to-door drive in run-up to Punjab poll

Press Trust of India
DHURI



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday launched the Aam Aadmi Party's (AAP) door-to-door election drive for the 2027 Assembly poll.

Pitching his government's 'Mann Da Munafa' narrative, Mr. Mann claimed that every family is receiving an annual benefit of ₹1.82 lakh from its welfare initiatives like free electricity and health care.

He said AAP would go to every household with its record of work undertaken since 2022, while asserting that the campaign would remain positive and focus on what the government has delivered for Punjab.

Mr. Mann said AAP would seek people's support based on the work delivered on the ground and question the Opposition over its record and the issue of combating drugs.

During the outreach, the Chief Minister went door to door in Dhuri, met several families and interacted with elderly residents, women, youngsters and children.

He listened to their views, discussed the work

undertaken by the government over the past four-and-a-half years and explained how various schemes and initiatives were translating into direct benefits for ordinary households.

'Not an abstract figure'

"Every family in Punjab is today benefiting by ₹1.82 lakh annually from the initiatives rolled out by our government. This is not an abstract figure. It represents money a household no longer has to take out of its own pocket for electricity, healthcare, education and other essential services," Mr. Mann said.

"I want every family to sit down and calculate for itself how much it is saving every month. That is the real meaning of 'Mann Da Munafa'," he added.

Why are students forced to live in unsafe paying guest facilities, Rahul asks govt.

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday hit out at the Modi government over the issue of hostel facilities for students. He asked why they are "forced to live in unsafe PGs" and also sought to know the status of the investigation into the Satya Niketan building collapse incident.

In a social media post, Mr. Gandhi shared pictures from the interaction he



Rahul Gandhi at a 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event in Indore. PTI

had on Saturday in Indore with the family of a student from Madhya Pradesh who died in the Satya Niketan building collapse in Delhi

on September 6. Seven persons, including five students, died in the incident. Among them was 21-year-old Arpit Jaj, a native of Devas in Madhya Pradesh. Mr. Gandhi invited Jaj's family on stage during his youth outreach programme 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' in Indore on Saturday.

'What was his fault?'

In his post in Hindi on X on Sunday, the Congress leader stated: "What was that

innocent soul's fault? This is the question being asked with tear-filled eyes by the family that lost their son in the Satya Niketan tragedy." Had there been good and safe hostels, Jaj's parents would not have been forced to house their son in such a dangerous place, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha said.

"Had safety standards truly been adhered to, perhaps this tragedy, would never have occurred," Mr. Gandhi added.

'Drought-hit taluks likely to cross 200 in Karnataka'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

More than 200 taluks in Karnataka are likely to be declared drought-affected, Deputy Chief Minister and Revenue Minister G. Parameshwara said on Sunday.

He also accused the Centre of discriminating against the State, adding that ₹17,000 crore due under the Jal Jeevan Mission is yet to be released.

SPOTLIGHT

Vikas Vasudeva

It has been over a week since Jish (name changed to protect privacy) arrived in India after completing his mandatory military service in Israel. He savours a lemon pie and ginger tea at a popular vegan bakery-cum-café located in the narrow market lane of Dharamkot, a misty village in Himachal Pradesh's rain-washed pine forests.

A popular destination among Israeli backpackers along the 'Hummus Trail', Dharamkot is about two to three kilometres uphill from Mcleodganj. "This is my second visit to India," he says.

He felt compelled to visit last year in May, hearing stories through the drumbeat of social media and his friends' first-hand accounts. He stayed in the country for nearly five months, first alone, and then for two and half months with his wife.

Dharamkot is known as Mini Israel, because a number of Israelis flock here after they complete their conscription terms. Around 80,000 Israelis visit India annually, according to a paper, "Decoding the hummus trail of India: regaining the lost prudence", published in 2022 in *Anatolia*, an international journal of tourism and hospitality research. "Last year, a little over 1 lakh foreign tourists visited Hima-

chal. This included visitors from Europe, Canada, the U.S., and Israel among other countries," says Bhanu Gupta, joint director at Himachal's Tourism Department.

This year, however, Dharamkot's narrow, stone-paved roads lined by tall pine trees look relatively deserted. The influx of Israeli travellers has been skewed and uneven, according to local hospitality players. Yet, over the years, the steady footfall of foreign tourists has helped the economy of this tiny village, even as the locals worry about the adverse impact of drug-laced raves in the forest.

Trailing peace

Jish says he and his wife are "here to relax" and will soon head out on their hired bike to Delhi and onward to Rajasthan. In Dharamkot, "There are different courses, like music sessions, yoga, drawing, and painting – there are so many options to unwind. In India, unlike Israel, there is more peace and nature, landscapes, and special people," he says, as he grabs his belongings to move for his painting class in lower Dharamkot, run by residents largely through hired instructors. Charcoal painting and pencil sketching are popular among foreign tourists in this Himalayan village.

The 'Hummus Trail' gets its name from hummus – a Middle Eastern food traditionally made from cooked

Getting away from gunshots

For many young Israelis, Dharamkot in Himachal Pradesh offers an escape from the pressures of military service and conflict, but locals in the tranquil Himalayan retreat worry about drug use and rave culture



Many Israeli tourists come to Dharamkot to relax after completing their conscription terms. R.V. MOORTHY

chickpeas, tahini (sesame paste), lemon juice, garlic, and olive oil. The trail has many cafés and restaurants catering to Israeli travellers. The route spans several places in the mighty mountains of the Himalayas, like Kasol, Old Manali, Rishikesh, and Ladakh. It stretches across Uttar Pradesh's Varanasi and Pushkar in Rajasthan, extending to South Goa, Gokarna and Hampi in Karnataka, and Vattakanal in Tamil Nadu.

Hodaya, 23, also from Israel, has come to Dharam-

kot with her friend, drawn by the popularity of the 'Hummus Trail'.

"Most Israelis follow the Shvil Hummus (Hummus Trail) route in India and Nepal, as it has many cafés with Hebrew menus, Israeli music, and food. I have been in India for about two months now, travelling between Manali, Leh, and Dharamkot. It's relaxing here," says Hodaya, who is set to return to Israel in a couple of days. Asked how she feels about the ongoing conflict, she shrugs it off with a smile,

saying, "I am used to it, so I am not stressed anymore."

Monetising tourism

The stone walls across Dharamkot are dotted with posters in Hebrew, alongside English. In lower Dharamkot, more accessible by road than the upper areas, the bulletin boards outside cafés, restaurants, roadside stalls, and homestays on the market stretch, serve as a news feed for different events for the village's international community. There are wellness workshops, music and art

events, community activities, and notices for parties.

Narendar Pathania, 54, who runs an eight-room guest house in Dharamkot, points out that the flow of Israeli travellers has been unsteady for the past three years. The first lull, he says, was in 2023. That year, on October 7, Hamas-led Palestinian armed groups crossed into southern Israel, killing more than 1,200 people.

The tourists, Pathania says, further dropped after the US-Israel and Iran conflict broke out in February 2026. "Almost all of them had left when the war with Iran started. Now some have returned, but the flow is lower. All my rooms, which used to be packed during these days, are vacant. It eventually brings loss. Tourism is the primary livelihood for many in our village," he says.

Vivek Kumar hails from neighbouring Dharamshala, manages routine affairs at 'Dharamkot studio' that offers pottery and ceramic courses in Dharamkot. He says, "Among the foreigners who come to us, Israelis make up the largest share. We have different courses ranging from five to 35 days. A minimum two-hour workshop is also available to experience the process of shaping wet clay into finished objects. Most of those who enrol with us are Israelis. In their country, these things are quite expensive, as I understand from speaking with them,"

he says.

Sanjeev Gandhi, chief advisor to the Hotel and Restaurant Association, Smart City, Dharamshala, who himself runs Hotel Gandhi's Paradise at Dharamkot, shares his experience on why Israelis are drawn to the town.

"Most Israelis come carrying the weight of war and stress. They come to forget. What they value most about Dharamshala is the silence," says Gandhi, recalling a number of them telling him that the biggest draw is that they don't hear gunshots.

Rage against the rave

The 'Hummus Trail', also notorious as the 'Hashish Trail', is a route taken for readily available cheap drugs, says the *Anatolia* paper. In June 2026, taking suo motu action, the Himachal Pradesh High Court directed the transfer of three senior officers, including the then Deputy Commissioner and Superintendent of Police of Kullu district, in connection with the alleged nexus between officials and organisers of big-scale rave parties in Kullu district.

Om Prakash Sharma, a former Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) officer, who handled several enforcement operations in Himachal, Punjab, and Jammu-Kashmir, while he worked with the NCB's Chandigarh zone from 2002 to 2007, asserts that cultivation of cannabis and opium in remote areas of Kullu district

and Mandi district of Himachal continues unabated.

"The narcotics trade cannot survive unless there's support from the socio-political and administrative strata. Foreigners have been found involved in the illicit drug trade," he says, adding that regular Himachali people get involved because of "local poverty" and "easy money".

"Rave parties in secluded forest areas are being organised in the name of tourism, which is not possible without the shelter of big-wigs and administrative machinery and local political patronage," he adds.

Monika Pathania, former councillor of Dharamkot ward, which falls under Dharamshala Municipal Corporation, says, "People talk about rave parties happening here, but that's simply not true. Such things don't happen at all in the village. It could be happening in remote areas where police presence is minimal, but in Dharamkot and neighbouring Bhagsnag there are police check posts to keep a tab on unlawful activities."

Gandhi is worried that locals too are impacted by drugs. "We have been urging the locals and administration to create a joint team to tackle the drug menace," he says.

For many young Israelis like Jish, Dharamkot is an escape from war, a holiday of healing and hash.

vikas.vasudeva@thehindu.co.in

INBRIEF



Sabarimala sees protests over Aravana prasadam shortage

The Sabarimala temple in Pathanamthitta, Keralam, witnessed protests by pilgrims on Saturday and Sunday after a shortage of Aravana left them waiting for hours, with several returning without the *prasadam*. Its supply was hit as the Aravana plant at the Sannidhanam remained shut for maintenance, ahead of the annual Mandalam-Makaravilakku pilgrim season. Devotees were given only three packets each of Appam and one tin each of Aravana on Sunday.

Cyberfraud network: 3 held, 507 bank accounts frozen

Investigating an online investment fraud involving ₹93.58 lakh, Karnataka Cyber Command sleuths have arrested three people and uncovered a network allegedly involved in procurement and supply of 507 bank accounts to fraudsters. These accounts have been frozen. As per the probe, the accused allegedly procured current, corporate and bank accounts, net banking credentials and linked SIM cards from account holders by offering them commissions.

Two people killed in separate road accidents in Vizag

Two people were killed and two others were seriously injured in separate road accidents in Visakhapatnam on Sunday. A 35-year-old woman was allegedly hit by a lorry and died on the spot at Isukathota Junction on NH-16. A couple on a two-wheeler with their four-year-old boy travelling to Anandapuram from Anakapalli were allegedly struck by a lorry. The man riding the vehicle died on the spot, while his wife and the child were taken to a hospital for treatment.

Keralam Minister's 'loaned' SUV drives him into a row

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Local Self-Governments Minister and Indian Union Muslim League leader K.M. Shaji's use of a luxury sports utility vehicle (SUV), purportedly borrowed from a Saudi Arabia-based businessperson friend, as his official car has snowballed into a major row. Mr. Shaji came under criticism for affixing the government registration plate reserved for vehicles of Cabinet Ministers, on a privately owned vehicle. He had initially tried to defend his use of the "borrowed" vehicle, claiming that the vehicle assigned to him had clocked over 4 lakh km and its roadworthiness was suspect.

Post and cuts
In a Facebook post titled "Shaji and Range Rover car," former Minister K.T. Jaleel flagged a "serious violation" of the oath of office on the part of the Minister. He alleged that Mr. Shaji accepted a freebie in contravention of the constitutional pledge not to show fear or favour while holding elected office. Subsequently, the Minister returned the SUV after he and the Congress-led United Democratic Front government arguably found themselves in "poor light," especially at a time when Keralam was reeling under rolling night-time power cuts exacerbated by paltry State finances. Nevertheless, on Sunday, Mr. Shaji on Facebook challenged the media to investigate whether he had done anything out of the way for his friends.

Congress alleges irregularities in BRS leaders' properties

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A delegation of Congress MPs, MLAs, and others alleged the BRS leadership in Telangana accumulated extensive landholdings and built farmhouses across the State, and questioned the source of the properties acquired by former Chief Minister K. Chandrasekhar Rao's (KCR) family and other BRS leaders. The delegation, comprising Bhongir MP Chama Kiran Kumar Reddy, Nagarkurnool MP Mallu Ravi, and MLAs, inspected the land and farmhouses in Aziznagar and Moinabad on Sunday and said the vi-

sits were part of a campaign to bring alleged irregularities in land transactions and farmhouse construction into the public domain. Mr. Kiran Kumar Reddy said Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy had referred to some of these lands in the Assembly. He asked how properties in Erraveli, Ranganaik Sagar, Janwada, Aziznagar and Moinabad came to be associated with the KCR family. He asked whether KCR had disclosed the Erravelli farmhouse in his 2004 poll affidavit. Mr. Reddy alleged BRS leadership introduced a "farmhouse culture" in Telangana.

Sleeping girl students' hair cut in A.P. residential school

The Hindu Bureau
VISAKHAPATNAM

Tension prevailed at the Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya school in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh, after the hair of several Class 9 girl students was allegedly cut while they were asleep on Saturday night, triggering concerns over security at the residential school. The incident came to light on Sunday morning, when some students complained their hair had been cut during the night. The reports initially led to speculation that outsiders might have entered the school premises, raising concerns over the safety and security of students, and creating panic on the

Police say the act was allegedly committed by other girl students, allay safety concerns
premises. The incident soon gained widespread attention on social media, further intensifying concerns among parents and the local community. Bheemunipatnam MLA Ganta Srinivasa Rao rushed to the school after learning about the incident, and took stock of the situation. **Police inspect premises** Bheemunipatnam Inspector G. Divakar and other police personnel also visited the school and inspect-

Royal exit



Off duty: Lekha, a sniffer dog of the Kochi City Police, being honoured with a shawl on her retirement after 11 years of service, at the Tripunithura Armed Reserve camp in Kerala on Sunday. THULASI KAKKAT

Raise issues concerning people in J&K Assembly's Autumn Session: NC chief

Press Trust of India
SRINAGAR

National Conference (NC) president Farooq Abdullah on Sunday asked MLAs to highlight the issues and demands of people in their respective constituencies during the Autumn Session of the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly. He was chairing a meeting of MLAs from the ruling NC, the Congress, CPI (M) and Independents supporting the government a day before the start of the Autumn Session. Mr. Abdullah empha-



NC president Farooq Abdullah

sised that the primary responsibility of legislators is to effectively articulate people's concerns in the

Neurosurgeon dies after car catches fire



A police officer and locals near the charred car after the collision. PTI

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A 50-year-old neurosurgeon was killed after the car he was driving rammed a divider and burst into flames on the Khammam-Hyderabad highway in Suryapet, Telangana, on Sunday morning. The police said drowsy driving could have led to the crash.

The deceased was identified as Kasakurti Jagadish, associated with Mamata Hospital in Khammam. According to a police officer, Dr. Jagadish was at the hospital till around 4 a.m. He then set out for Hyderabad to meet his family when the accident occurred around 7.15 a.m. Eyewitnesses said the doctor was alone in the car.

graphic Decline and Advancement of Women, Adolescent Girls, Maternal and Child Health Bill, 2026', the proposed legislation has been forwarded to the Assembly Secretariat for consideration during the Autumn Session. The Bill, also known as 'Maa-Beti Aur Aane Wali Naslein Bachao Bill, 2026', seeks to combine measures for women's health and empowerment with voluntary and non-coercive measures intended to address the long-term consequences of sustained below-replacement fertility.

Populated areas will be removed from ESA: Siddique

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

The Keralam government is taking steps to ensure the exclusion of inhabited and agricultural areas from the proposed Ecologically Sensitive Area (ESA) in the Western Ghats, Agriculture Minister T. Siddique said. He said the Centre's seventh draft ESA notification, issued on July 25, covers 9,993.7 sq km across 131 villages. The State intends to have more than 30 villages removed from the list. In the remaining villages, it will seek exclusion of inhabited areas and agricultural land from the ESA limits, Mr. Siddique said.

Mudslides, flash flood triggered by heavy rainfall leave five people dead in Keralam

The Hindu Bureau
IDUKKI

Five people have been killed in Keralam over the past two days due to mudslides and flash flood triggered by heavy rainfall. Two people were killed and one was seriously injured after a mudslide destroyed a makeshift shed on a garlic farm in Idukki on Sunday. According to the police, the deceased have been identified as Balakrishnan, 50, and his sister Chinnu, 35. Balakrishnan's wife, Mariyamma, 40, has been admitted to Munnar Government Hospital. The three were working on the farm when the area experienced heavy rain. They sought shelter in a temporary shed when a



Deadly downpour: The mudslide-hit area at Kottakkamboor, near Vattavada, in Idukki on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

mudslide struck the hill. Devikulam Subcollector V.M. Arya said the mudslide was triggered by torrential rainfall. "During the incident, an electric pole also fell onto the shed. It is suspected that electrocution may have caused the deaths, but this has not yet been confirmed. The exact

cause of the deaths will be determined only after the post-mortem," she said. Food and Civil Supplies Minister Anoop Jacob said the government would provide financial aid to the affected families. One person drowned, and four others were feared to have been swept away in a sudden flash

flood at Kottappuzha near Nilambur on Sunday afternoon. According to residents, five persons who were on the riverbank were caught in the unexpected surge. The body of the victim was recovered after a search. The police and Fire and Rescue Services personnel continued the search into the night. A 35-year-old woman from Tamil Nadu was killed and another person injured in a mudslide that hit the Velathusseri region along the Erattupetta-Wagamon road on Sunday. One person was killed after a landslide dragged soil onto a house in Poonjar Nadubhagam on Saturday. Two others inside the house were rescued.

High SIR deletions point to structural flaws, says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



A voter in Delhi Cantonment constituency, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu's name was flagged over 'self-name mismatch'. PTI

Bhatt was flagged for a “self-name mismatch” and senior advocate Huzefa Ahmadi for no mapping.



Citing State-wise data, he said 53.73% of voters face the risk of deletion in Delhi, 52.58% in Chandigarh, 39.57% in Jharkhand, 35.71% in Uttarakhand, 35.36% in Meghalaya, 33.88% in Maharashtra, 48.90% in Telangana, 27.6% in Karnataka, 37.5% in Haryana, 23.67% in Odisha, 21.17% in Andhra Pradesh and 15.23% in Punjab.

Protest against the UGC's draft caste discrimination regulations called off

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Union Minister J.P. Nadda



Union Minister J.P. Nadda

In his statement after the meeting with the Ministers, Mr. Shekhawat said, "Talks with the government have already begun on all the major demands for which this *mahapanchayat* was proposed, and the government has taken it seriously. We hope that the upcoming talks will yield concrete and positive decisions toward resolving all these discrepancies."

Northeast's largest power project initiated in Assam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma during the launch of the thermal power plant at Chapar in Dhubri district. X/@HIMANTABISWA

"The thermal plant will provide reliable and affordable electricity to support homes, businesses, and industries," he added.

‘Keen to explore ways to reset, renew Indo-Nepal ties’

Nepal Finance Minister says old era of jingoism and equating Nepali nationalism with anti-Indianism is over; during his visit to Delhi for meetings post the August floods, he pushes for revising trade treaty and connectivity plans; the economist says the Balen Shah government has spoken about some big signature projects or forms of assistance which can be adapted to the reconstruction needs

INTERVIEW
Swarnim Wagle

Suhasini Haidar

A month after floods wrecked areas in Nepal, its new government is intensifying efforts for reconstruction support. Nepal’s Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle, an economist and former UNDP official, made his first visit abroad to Delhi to discuss plans with the Centre, and will soon travel to meetings of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), the International Monetary Fund (IMF), and the World Bank to seek support for an estimated \$5-billion recovery project. Mr. Wagle said the new Balen Shah government wants a “reset” with India, and a revision of old trade and connectivity projects, including pushing for long-delayed overflight rights for Nepal airports. Edited excerpts:

What is your estimate of the losses to Nepal from the Bhotekoshi floods?

Relying on government sources, the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) has estimated an early figure of about \$1.8 billion of direct damages and around \$900 million of losses, but all that’s at replacement value. However, we’re not going to simply replace what existed before, but rebuild for resilience in the future, and that’s going to be more costly. We’re estimating 4.7 to 5 billion dollars of reconstruction needs over the next three to five years.

How can India help? What specifically did you discuss during your visit to Delhi about projects that India can be involved in?

India has been very supportive, very proactive even in reaching out to us and we are keen to explore ways we can reset and re-

new Indo-Nepal ties. We have talked about some big signature projects or forms of assistance, which I think can be adapted to the reconstruction needs. After the 2015 earthquake, India had given us about \$250 million of grant assistance and \$750 million of LOC (line of credit). Now, some LOCs would need to go into the rehabilitation of our energy infrastructure.

Publicly built hydropower plants, transmission lines, sub-stations would ideally be addressed through concessional credit. But projects like roads and bridges and even public housing, I think would benefit from grant-based assistance. We leave it to the Government of India to organise their package in a way they feel appropriate.

Nepal’s Foreign Minister had also said that big climate polluters India, China, and the U.S. bear some of the responsibility for this flooding, and that they owe Nepal reparations.



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Would you agree?

At this point in time, I think that line of thinking is rather unhelpful for us and for countries that have generously stepped in to help. However, some of these issues will come up at CoP conferences, including the next one in Turkiye (November). We need to look at this event scientifically. The World Weather Attribution Group has concluded that climate change contributed to the thaw of the permafrost and to glacial

thinning. All sorts of global warming effects are visible in the Himalayas - and permafrost, the mud, the mountain wall that was held together is now just cracking up.

As ties now improve, when do you expect PM Balen Shah will visit India?

I think Prime Minister Balen’s visit to India will happen well before the end of the year. And this will be his first bilateral visit

abroad. He is planning to make a quick trip to the United Nations [next week], and will address the UN General Assembly on the 24th and return immediately. The only thing on his schedule right now is a courtesy call on the UN Secretary-General. His formal bilateral engagements will begin with India.

RSP [Rastriya Swatantra Party] leaders have spoken of a reset with India, and promised a relationship without any “old baggage”. Does this mean the boundary dispute will not be an issue?

We don’t carry much of the baggage [of the past]. It’s not that we’re going to shy away from some issues that might be uncomfortable to discuss, but we’ll do it in a constructive way. The old era of jingoism and equating Nepali nationalism with anti-Indianism is over. We reject that. We also have to update the trade treaty, and that is an issue I

have taken up with both (External Affairs Minister) Jaishankar and (Finance Minister) Sitharaman.

I think it’s incumbent upon us to seek that partnership to integrate with the Indian supply chain and for that you need big connectivity but thin borders. This is the Southeast Asian model that we have not emulated in South Asia yet.

On air connectivity, did you get any assurances from the Indian government? It has been several years since Nepal requested overflight for airports in Bhairahawa and Pokhara.

There’s a bilateral mechanism on this issue which has been reactivated and it’s going to meet very soon. And this time it’s going to include defence officials as well. [Allowing overflight] will help Indian airlines too as it will reduce flight time, airfares and increase trade and tourism... There may

be some sensitivities on the Bhairahawa airport route because of Gorakhpur airbase, but that has to be seen with the new possibilities this will open up for India.

How would your government navigate issues that India has with Chinese-funded and built projects, like in hydropower?

India hasn’t said don’t involve the Chinese in any sector... just in sectors where India is procuring electricity. That’s what we’ve been communicated. It used to be vague and now it’s explicit which is helpful that this is the clear line and we can plan accordingly. I do believe that the media has a role in making some of the figures more transparent and analysing the trends. I did sense an element of paranoia in the way China-related stories are covered in the region. (For full interview, go to: [newsth.live/waglenepal](#))

Trump’s tariff decision can hurt energy security, trade, economy of India: Cong.

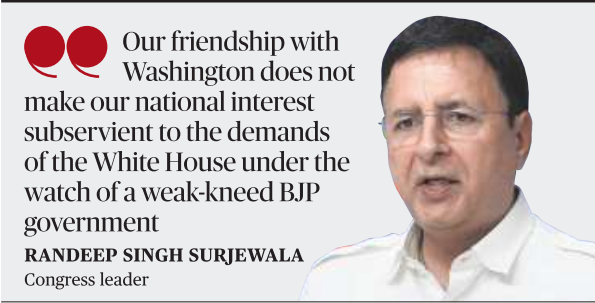
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress has termed United States President Donald Trump’s decision to impose 100% tariffs on countries buying Russian oil as an unjustified action, warning that the move has serious implication for India’s energy security, economy, and trade.

Congress Working Committee member and former Union Commerce Minister Anand Sharma and Congress general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala warned, in separate statements on Sunday, against “surrendering” to U.S. dictates, stressing that it is the Centre’s sovereign duty to secure affordable energy for 140 crore people.

Mr. Trump’s decision to sign the Lindsay Graham Bill into an Act that empowers him to impose 100% tariffs on countries buying Russian oil is a matter of grave concern, Mr. Sharma said.

“India is a major importer of Russian crude oil accounting for over half of crude petroleum imports this year, as the U.S. Israel attack on Iran and the West Asia conflict caused a serious disruption of oil and



gas supply globally and a sharp rise in petroleum and gas prices,” he said.

“It is ironic that the U.S. itself is annually importing uranium and fertilizers valued at over \$4 billion. These have been carefully kept out of the ambit of the Graham Act. This is hypocrisy and double standards,” he said, adding that the arbitrary targeting of strategic partner countries, including India, is unjustified, unacceptable, and condemnable.

‘Abject capitulation’

Mr. Surjewala said that India is a sovereign republic with the right to buy energy from any nation that meets India’s national interests and at a price its people can afford.

“Our friendship with Washington does not make our national interest subservient to the demands of

the White House under the watch of a weak-kneed BJP government. Securing affordable energy for 140 crore people is our sovereign duty,” he said.

He added the sad story today was the “abject capitulation” by the Modi-led government, at the cost of the Indian economy.

“After 12 years of ‘Vishwaguru’ rhetoric, the Modi government has failed to build the counter-leverage needed to protect India from external economic pressure, nor does it show the courage to stand on equal ground and stand for our people and the nation,” Mr. Surjewala said.

He added that while private refiners captured billions from discounted Russian crude, the government had left an \$86.5 billion export economy exposed to Washington’s coercion.

BJP leaders criticise mimicry of Modi at Rahul’s Indore event

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

A political row erupted in Madhya Pradesh on Sunday, as BJP leaders slammed Congress leader Rahul Gandhi for featuring the mimicry of Prime Minister Narendra Modi by stand-up comedian Pulkit Mani at a student interaction event in Indore.

Mr. Gandhi, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, could be seen laughing during the performance by Mr. Mani at his *Chhatron Ki Goonj* event. In the act, Mr. Mani appeared to be mimicking Mr. Modi’s interactions with foreign leaders and others. While Mr. Mani did not name the Prime Minister in his act, Mr. Gandhi said, “How are you, Modi-ji?”, while hugging him.

Another part of the act, where Mr. Mani appeared to be mocking the Prime Minister for asking for a chair for an elderly woman at a rally, took the most heat. Similar performances by the comedian have previously gone viral on social media.

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav shared a clip of the act and said that Mr. Gandhi’s attitude was “extremely

‘Extremely shameful’, misleading youth, says M.P. CM; ‘cheap political theatre,’ says Union Minister

shameful”. “This irresponsible attitude of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi is extremely shameful, condemnable, and unbecoming. By insulting the honour of our country’s culture and mothers, he has encouraged leading the youth’s future in the wrong direction,” he wrote on X, late on Saturday.

Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal said the act amounted to “cheap political theatre”.

“Uncultured angry uncle! The irony writes itself. The need to come on stage every now and then just to drag Prime Minister Modi-ji’s name into cheap political theatre never fails to amaze me. Look in the mirror, Mr. Rahul Gandhi,” Mr. Goyal said on X.

Following the controversy, Mr. Mani said in an Instagram story that his upcoming show, scheduled to be held in Uttar Pradesh’s Noida, had been cancelled “due to unforeseen circumstances”.

Tejashwi flays Bihar’s flood relief efforts, says money wasted on PM’s birthday

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Assembly Tejashwi Yadav on Sunday criticised the ruling National Democratic Alliance government over flood relief efforts in the State and the money spent on Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s birthday celebrations. He also called Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and Bharatiya Janata Party national president Nitin Nabin “rubber stamps”.

Mr. Yadav, who is also the national working president of the Rashtriya Janata Dal, said Mr. Nabin, who is from Bihar, could not even get Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to visit the flood-hit State. He said the decision of several NDA leaders, including Mr. Choudhary and Mr. Nabin, to donate their monthly salaries towards flood relief was just “drama to divert attention”.

“Have the Prime Minister and Mr. Shah donated their salaries? How much money did all the NDA MLAs and MPs donate? Not more than ₹3 crore to the Chief Minister’s Relief Fund. More than this, the



Hitting out: RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav addressing a press conference at his official residence in Patna on Sunday. PTI

NDA leaders wasted public money by lighting diyas on the birthday of Mr. Modi. The Bihar CM and Mr. Nabin are just rubber stamps of Mr. Modi,” Mr. Yadav said. He termed the lighting of lamps as being akin to rubbing salt on the wounds of flood victims, and asked whether NDA leaders’ contribution of “₹2 crore-₹3 crore” was sufficient for the “50 lakh people affected by the flood”.

Drought woes

Mr. Yadav pointed out that over the past 28 days, Bihar has been grappling not only with floods, but also drought. “The State has received less than 35% of its normal rainfall. Due to the severe drought, crops across lakhs of hectares of

land are being destroyed. Lakhs of farmers are unable to even recover their input costs. The government has not yet even assessed the drought situation and farmers are facing a livelihood crisis,” he said.

He claimed that a handful of community kitchens and relief camps were set up as a token gesture and that they were now shut due to a lack of funds.

He asked why Bihar was not assisted through the Prime Minister’s National Relief Fund. “The number of people affected by floods in Bihar exceeds the total combined population of several other States... Yet, the Home Minister and the Prime Minister show no concern for Bihar. Is this not discrimination against Bihar?” he said.

Kurmis will be kept outside ambit of Uniform Civil Code, says Bengal CM

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Sunday said the Kurmi community would be kept outside the ambit of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC).

He also announced that cases registered against members of the community during protests under the previous Trinamool Congress government would be withdrawn.

The Kurmis are a prominent community in the State’s Jangalmahal region. They are currently categorised as Other Backward Class and have been de-



Suwendu Adhikari

manding the status of Scheduled Tribe (ST).

They have also been seeking the inclusion of the Kurmali language in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution. Members of

the Kurmi community had organised road and railway blockades across parts of West Bengal during the previous Trinamool Congress government’s tenure, demanding ST status and inclusion of the Kurmali language in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution.

‘Push for recognition’

Mr. Adhikari promised to push for constitutional recognition of the Kurmali and Rajbanshi languages.

The West Bengal government has said it would submit a “Further Common Justification Report” to the Centre to support

the inclusion of the Kurmi community in the ST list.

On the UCC, the State government has set up a committee led by former Supreme Court judge Ranjana Gopal Desai to work out the modalities for implementing the proposed code in the State. The government has already promised to keep ST out of the ambit of the UCC.

Addressing a Karam festival programme in Purulia, he accused the previous government of creating divisions within the community and said his government would fulfil the promises made in its election manifesto.

151 Ambedkar statues vandalised in BJP-led U.P., alleges Akhilesh Yadav

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday alleged that over 151 statues of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar had been vandalised across 72 districts during the BJP nine-and-a-half-year rule in Uttar Pradesh.

Releasing a ‘Samajwadi audit report’, Mr. Yadav alleged the incidents were part of a wider pattern in humiliating marginalised social groups and Ambedkarites. “The vandalism is a deliberate act of humiliating oppressed social groups and followers of Dr.



Samajwadi Party national president Akhilesh Yadav at a press conference in Lucknow on Sunday. ANI

Ambedkar. As the BJP failed to change the Constitution, they are indulging in such acts [of vandalism] out of frustration,” he told

presspersons here.

Arrests had been made in only 14 such instances of vandalism, he said.

“Cases have been regis-

tered against 45 unknown persons; 18 people have been named as accused across incidents. In 84 incidents, there are no details on any action taken. An attack on Babasaheb Ambedkar is an attack on the soul of India and a slap on democratic values. It shows the BJP government and its feudal followers have no respect for Dr. Ambedkar and ideas of equality,” he said.

The Opposition party further claimed that the audit report was part of a larger outcry for social justice, and it would ultimately lead to the overthrow of the BJP government.

INBRIEF



Rampur Hounds join India-U.S. troops for specialised drills

Indian Army’s military dogs, including indigenous Rampur Hounds, are showcasing their specialised operational skills alongside U.S. Army personnel during the ongoing India-U.S. bilateral exercise Yudh Abhyas 2026. According to the Indian Army, four Army Canines - Rampur Hounds Victor and Rowdy, Belgian Malinois Zac and Labrador Retriever Rice are participating in the exercise, demonstrating their capabilities in room intervention and rappelling drills as part of the professional exchanges with the U.S. Army. Rampur Hounds are increasingly being inducted for specialised military roles. Its participation in the exercise highlights Army’s efforts to employ indigenous canine breeds for operational tasks.

FPIs withdraw ₹20,974 crore from equities in September

Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have turned cautious again, pulling out ₹20,974 crore from Indian equities so far in September amid global uncertainties, higher U.S. interest rates and bond yields, elevated crude oil prices and a weakening rupee. The latest outflow comes after foreign investors returned to Indian equities in July and August, when they invested ₹20,200 crore and ₹29,630 crore, respectively, according to data from CDSL. With the September selling, FPIs have now withdrawn a total of ₹2.45 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026, surpassing the ₹1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded during the entire 2025. PTI

SC calls for law to safeguard multi-crore court deposits

SC highlights absence of uniform rules governing money deposited by litigants; it says asymmetry in treating deposits is causing further pendency, wants these protected from ad-hoc management

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

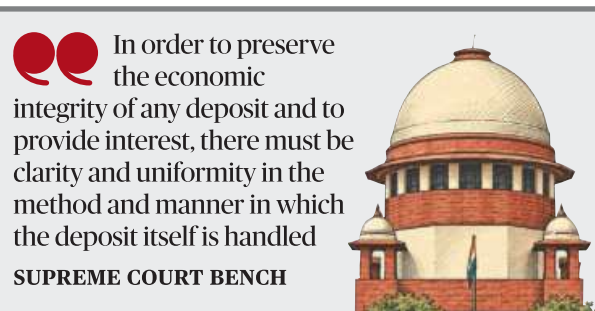
A law is necessary to protect crores deposited by litigants across courts and tribunals in the country during pending appeals, the Supreme Court said in a recent judgment.

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe observed that litigants’ money should be saved from ad-hoc management while calling for nationwide legislative reform to standardise how courts and tribunals handle money deposited during pending litigation.

The top court pointed out the problem of the absence of uniform rules governing court-ordered deposits. For example, a court would direct a litigant to deposit money in order to get a stay while his or her appeal is heard out.

So far, individual courts and tribunals have passed orders on deposits and their investment during the pendency of appeals on a case-to-case basis.

This, the court said, has left huge sums of money entangled in financial instruments across different banks, earning inconsis-



tent interest rates and triggering post-judgment litigation over the interest-accounting of their deposits.

The Bench said the pressure of inflation and economic uncertainties also add to the anxieties about rates of interest on the deposits.

“In order to preserve the economic integrity of any deposit and to provide interest, there must be clarity and uniformity in the method and manner in which the deposit itself is handled. Lack of standardisation in the process by which sums deposited into the court are to be handled undermines this essential underlying principle of the time value of money as well as the accrual of interest in a certain and clear manner,” the recent verdict observed.

Further, the top court

pointed out that the asymmetry in treating deposits made by litigants is leading to further pendency across courts.

“Lack of common standards and consistent principles are resulting in repeated determinations of routine questions concerning investment, renewal, quantum, accounting and interest on deposits, thereby increasing the burden on courts/tribunals,” the Bench observed.

U.S. model

The court suggested the U.S. model of having a common platform where deposits made in courts and tribunals were pooled into one unified scheme and put into the most beneficial financial instrument for the litigating parties.

“This common platform will not only create certain-

ty in the interest rates and increase the ease of accessibility for litigants but will also ease the burden on courts/tribunals regarding how this money deposited is to be invested and dealt with,” Justice Narasimha observed.

The apex court recommended a statutory framework modelled after international precedents, specifically pointing to the United States’ Court Registry Investment System.

“We are of the opinion that it is necessary to evolve and formulate suitable legislation on the subject. We request the Law Commission of India to examine the issues which we have highlighted and, in the process, also consider the laws which other countries have enacted. It may be necessary for the Law Commission to consult the Reserve Bank of India, Ministry of Finance and also the nodal Ministry of Law and Justice,” the apex court directed.

The Bench directed the judgment copy to be forwarded to the Law Commission chairperson; RBI Governor; and Secretaries to the Ministries of Finance, and Law and Justice.



The mangled remains of the car that plunged nearly 75 feet from the Mumbai Coastal Road on Sunday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Three youth killed as ‘speeding’ luxury car crashes in Mumbai

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Three youth were killed and one was critically injured on Sunday after the car they were travelling in went out of control on the Coastal Road in Mumbai and plunged nearly 75 feet into an under-construction site.

The police said the incident occurred around 5 a.m. when the luxury car was moving from Marine Drive towards north Mumbai. The driver appeared to have lost control because of high speed, the police said.

The deceased were identified as Sanay Gujjar, 21; Aditya Jakasania, 19; and Dhairya Sheth, 17. Gujjar was driving the car. The injured youth, Aditya Os-

wal, 23, is undergoing treatment at a hospital. He is in a critical condition.

The Mumbai Coastal Road is a 10.58-km high-speed freeway connecting Marine Drive to the Worli end of the Bandra-Worli Sea Link.

Tardeo police station senior inspector Meena Jagtap said, “It appears that the car was travelling at a very high speed and the driver lost control before the vehicle hit the Coastal Road barrier and fell, killing three students and injuring another.”

Gujjar, Oswal, and Sheth were students of a management college in Vile Parle. Gujjar was from Ahmedabad and was staying as a paying guest in Mumbai. The BMW belonged to his family.

Study attempts to find out how India made diabetes medicines affordable

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A study by Chennai-based diabetologists has attempted to find out how India has managed to reduce the prices of new and expensive diabetes drugs and what lessons this could possibly hold for other low- and middle-income countries (LMIC). The study, “Making Modern Diabetes Medications Affordable and Accessible: Lessons from India for Other Countries”, was led by V. Mohan, chairman, Dr. Mohan’s Diabetes Specialties Centre, Chennai, and was published in the journal *Diabetes Care*.

What did the study find? Of the 589 million adults in the world with diabetes, 80% live in LMICs, the study noted. Modern diabetes therapies such as GLP-1 re-

ceptor agonists as well as SGLT2i (sodium-glucose cotransporter 2 inhibitors) improve cardiovascular and renal outcomes, while analogue insulins help reduce the risk of hypoglycaemia. However, affordability remains a barrier: diabetes requires lifelong care and management of complications.

India’s ability to maintain low medication prices is closely linked to its role as a major pharmaceutical exporter, the paper stated, noting the strategic legislative history of maintaining critical safeguards to prevent “patent evergreening” and allowing for generic manufacture of drugs. It also found that the country has increasingly focused on strengthening domestic manufacturing capacity. There are concerns over global trade policies affecting prices

and the availability of raw materials. A government incentive scheme has been introduced to promote domestic manufacturing of raw materials, and as of 2025, production has commenced for 26 molecules that were previously imported.

The paper notes that metformin and sulfonylureas continue to form the foundation of type 2 diabetes management in India – both are included in the National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM). While DPP-4 (dipeptidyl peptidase 4) inhibitors, SGLT2i and GLP-1 RA have all been introduced, they are not currently in the NLEM. Initial uptake of these drugs was constrained by pricing. Following the competitive entry by multiple domestic manufacturers, the price of semaglutide, for instance in India, has

dropped considerably, and there has been a huge increase in sales.

Quick availability of generic and biosimilar drugs, deliberate regulatory and distribution strategies such as the government’s Jan Aushadhi Kendras, and market competition have allowed for affordable drugs in India, the paper highlighted.

Challenges ahead

Challenges that remain include urban-rural disparities in distribution and availability of medicines; tight regulations potentially affecting chances of drug innovation; differences in quality between generics and difficulties in maintaining strict pharmacovigilance; as well as limited formal evaluation of government schemes to look at their long-term impact on clinical outcomes.

The Hindu Sustainability Summit to explore impactful climate initiatives

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

As businesses, governments, and communities navigate the growing imperatives of climate action and sustainable development, *The Hindu*, in association with Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (CPCL), will host *The Hindu Sustainability Summit*, 2026 on Wednesday from 10 a.m. onwards.

Themed “CSR for a Sustainable Tomorrow”, the summit will bring together leading voices from industry, government, academia, and the wider sustainability ecosystem to examine how responsible leadership, innovation, and collaboration can translate sustainability ambitions into measurable impact. The summit will be inaugurated by V.K. Rajeev, Minister for Environment



THE HINDU
Sustainability Summit 2026
CSR for a Sustainable Tomorrow

and Climate Change, Government of Tamil Nadu. H. Shankar, Managing Director, CPCL, and Kumar Jayant, IAS, Chairman and Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Ltd. (TNPL), will be the Guests of Honour.

Eight sessions
The full-day summit will feature eight insightful sessions, comprising fireside conversations, panel discussions and presentations, bringing together di-

verse perspectives on some of the most pressing sustainability challenges and opportunities. The discussions will explore the transformation of refineries into future-ready energy hubs, innovative approaches to wastewater management and the role of circularity in building resilient water systems. Other sessions will examine how ESG, data and digital innovation can help drive more impactful CSR initiatives, alongside the future of sustainable cooling and process heating. The summit will also delve into India’s transition from fossil fuels to net zero, the role of start-ups in accelerating the energy transition, and how the banking sector can support the financing of a sustainable future. A session on real estate and sustainability will exa-

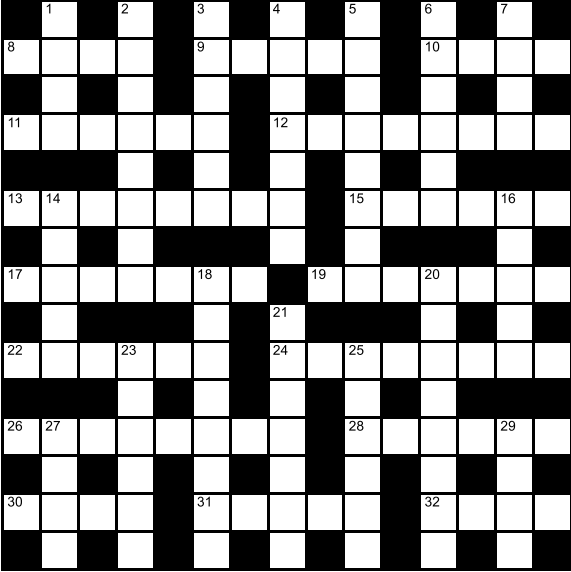
mine how the sector can balance growth with environmental responsibility. The summit is supported by CPCL as the Presenting Partner, with NLC India Ltd., Larsen & Toubro (L&T), Navin’s, WABAG, Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Ltd., Indian Bank, Urbando, and State Bank of India as Associate Partners. The summit’s sustainability-focused partnerships include Thermax as the Sustainable Cooling Partner, Treeni as the Sustainability Intelligence Partner, Chennai Port Authority as the Blue Economy Partner, and Tamil Nadu Green Climate Company as the Climate Action Partner. Mangaldeep is the Fragrance Partner, Puthiya Thalaimurai the TV Partner, The Federal the Digital TV Partner and Communi-tree the NGO Partner.



CROSSWORD **14903**
(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>





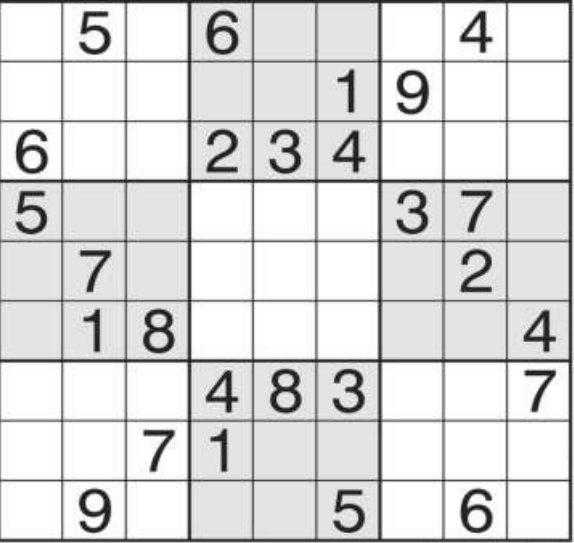
Across

8 Wine from cantina stinks (4)
9 Worries returned in Winchester farm (5)
10 Fastener from damaged part removed from air plant repaired (4)
11 Cops from Napoli centre (6)
12 Non believers at theft (8)

Down

13 Hence ads may be converted into money (8)
15 Acceptable, perhaps, to band wrongly (3,3)
17 Hoffman hugs boy producing receptacle for waste (7)
19 Zulu and Maori danced at end of season for royalty from Calicut (7)
22 Novelist from Australia in front of god (6)
24 Herons flying around setter and riders from the cavalry (8)
26 12 months, but longer than usual? (4,4)
28 Actor who played The Godfather gives up love for Yankee liquor (6)
30 Scotsman gets English spice (4)
31 Ms Adler’s nurse is in anger (5)
32 Positive response after European sees (4)

SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

W	S	K	B	C	G	T		
K	A	K	M	A	H	O	A	G
K	M	K	L	H	A	G	E	
S	O	M	A	L	I	N	G	O
T	N	A	S	I	K	I	E	
S	C	O	R	R	I	P	T	I
M	E	A	N	D	E	R	A	L
D	E	A	N	D	E	R	A	L
F	O	R	A	S	E	T	I	M
N	A	V	I	G	A	T	E	D
L	O	G	E	N	T	E	R	N
R	I	C	H	E	D	E	D	E
F	T	H	E	T	Y	O	E	

Solution to yesterday’s Sudoku

2	1	5	4	9	7	8	6	3
6	3	9	5	1	8	4	7	2
8	7	4	6	3	2	1	9	5
7	8	2	9	6	5	3	4	1
5	6	3	1	7	4	9	2	8
9	4	1	8	2	3	7	5	6
3	9	8	2	4	6	5	1	7
4	2	7	3	5	1	6	8	9
1	5	6	7	8	9	2	3	4

FAITH

Vidura’s dharma sukshma

After the Pandavas leave for the forest, Dhritarashtra is uneasy, and seeks Vidura’s advice, said Kidambi Narayanan in a discourse. He says Vidura knows dharma sukshma. Dharma sukshma goes beyond merely knowing the rules. It means a person knows how to react in a particular situation, how to analyse a situation and come to the right conclusion. Only those with experience in dealing with problems of various kinds will have dharma sukshma. Dhritarashtra is aware that Vidura has jnana, which includes knowledge of dharma too. Dhritarashtra is worried. He knows his family cannot get away unhurt if they hurt the Pandavas. Not only will they have to face the wrath of the Pandavas, but will have to deal with the displeasure of the people too. He tells Vidura that whatever Sakuni did was for the welfare of Duryodhana. But he knows that dharma was not adhered to in his court. He asks Vidura how to atone for what happened in the royal assembly.

Vidura says seeking wealth and pleasures must be within the boundaries of dharma. The foundation of governance is dharma. Dhritarashtra must not only be keen to protect his sons, but must also want to protect the Pandavas. “You are prejudiced against the Pandavas. You must come out of this mindset. A king should not covet other people’s wealth. At least from now on, stop troubling the Pandavas. If the Kauravas continue to torment the Pandavas, your family will be destroyed. The Pandavas should be brought back. Yudhishtira is not ambitious. A kingdom will be safe only in the hands of such a king,” Vidura tells Dhritarashtra.

Behind every treated animal stands a veterinarian carrying unseen strain

Unlike human medicine, where every organ often has its own specialist, veterinary medicine asks one person to be all of them at once

Vasini Varadan

While much of society is preoccupied with animal rights, there is a population facing a significant risk of burnout yet which often goes unacknowledged: veterinarians.

Often underestimated as a profession and underfunded as a field, veterinary medicine carries expectations that far exceed what can reasonably be asked of any one individual. Veterinarians are expected to deliver unwavering care, often at the cost of their own.

Like all healthcare professionals, they navigate long hours, emergencies, and loss. But they also have distinct challenges. Their patients cannot speak, forcing vets to rely on instinct as much as expertise. They must master multiple anatomies across species. They absorb not only the suffering of animals, but also the emotional intensity of anxious, grieving pet owners. And uniquely, they carry the burden of deciding when a life should end, often without adequate emotional support for the weight of the decisions made and the grief that comes with executing it.

What they experience is not simply burnout, a condition caused by prolonged stress, but also compassion fatigue (from caring unconditionally) and moral injury (having to make decisions that go against their core moral beliefs). Over time, all of this takes a toll.

Unlike human medicine, where every

organ has its own specialist, veterinary medicine asks one person to be all of them at once. Across a single day, they shift roles constantly: diagnosing, fixing, reassuring, improvising. It's not just about treating animals, it's about carrying an entire system of care in one body, adapting to whatever walks (or is carried) through the door.

Alongside their patients, vets take on the emotional aftermath, anger, disappointment, and grief of pet owners. They linger long after the consultation ends. A euthanasia need not end the day. It is often followed by the next appointment with no space or time in between to process the loss or the weight of the decision.

The rise of alternative medicine which is often cheaper brings another consequence: time lost. If the alternate treatment has not worked, there is delay in diagnosis, treatment and loss of life which falls at the hands of the vet.

Burnout, compassion fatigue, and moral injury show up in both mind and body as insomnia, brain fog, exhaustion, memory lapses and sometimes other physical illnesses.

Their work is not the problem. Most vets still care deeply about healing. It is a system defined by overwork, emotional labour, a variety of pressures, tough decisions, and financial limitations: it is meant to support them but often does the opposite.

(Vasini Varadan is a cartoonist and illustrator. vasinivaradan@gmail.com)



Like all healthcare professionals, vets navigate long hours, emergencies, and loss. But they also face distinct challenges. Representative image. MIKHAIL NILOV/PEXELS



A study found that poachers consistently targeted 'charismatic' and high-value species, such as macaws, at unsustainable rates. GETTY IMAGES

Urban demand is reorganising global wildlife trafficking web

Divya Gandhi

Some 2,000 km away from their natural habitat in the rainforests of Borneo and Sumatra, five listless baby orangutans were found, bafflingly, in a forest in the middle of Odisha on September 8. Videos were shared widely showing the critically endangered apes, each around a year old, with limited mobility, huddled together, chomping on bananas from a container. Then more videos emerged of the group being bottle-fed in a Bhubaneswar Zoo, where they are now being monitored.

Jose Louies, CEO of the Wildlife Trust of India, said it is clear these animals had been kept in captivity for a while, going by their complete lack of fear of humans. CITES prohibits the commercial trade in orangutans but these animals are routinely sold as exotic pets and can cost up to ₹20 lakh each. The discovery has renewed discourse on wildlife trafficking. India's Wildlife Crime Control Bureau has been asked to investigate the matter. There are many enigmas: How were they trafficked? By sea? Air? Road? Who captured and smuggled them? And who are their collectors? This is not the first time these apes have been found in India. In 2022, two baby orangutans were found abandoned near the Assam-Mizoram border.

A study published in the *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* has integrated 30 years of confiscation data and spatial network analysis to unravel the trade routes of another much-trafficked species, Mexico's parrots, from biodiverse habitats to urban centres around the world, and could provide clues to criminal networks in other parts of the world.

Today, urban centres are the nexuses of demand, the paper added. "For many commonly traded species, confiscations occurred hundreds of kilometers from their native habitats, frequently in major cities like Mexico City." And this demand is reorganising the global wildlife trafficking network.

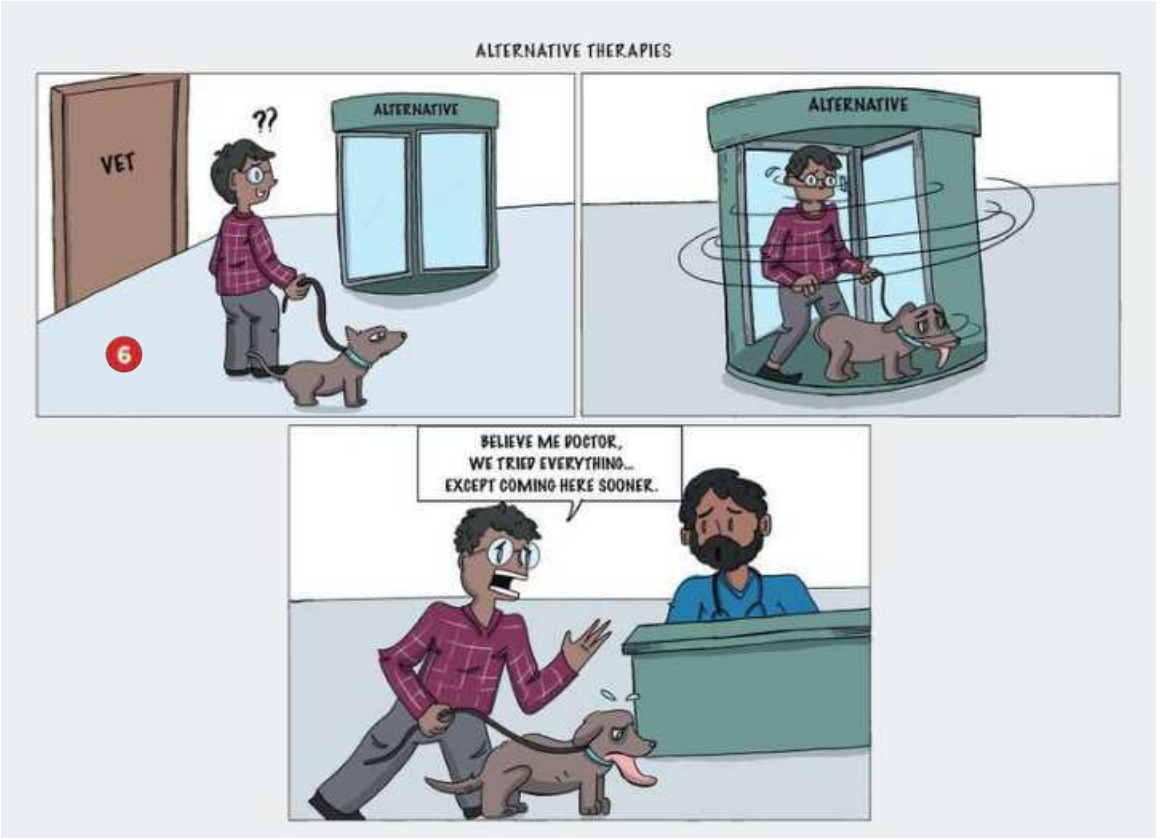
No less than half of Mexico's native parrot species are directly threatened by the illegal wildlife trade, the researchers said, "elevating their risk of extinction". They found that poachers consistently targeted "charismatic," and high-value species, particularly macaws and Amazon parrots.

The team's methods can be adapted to map other complex illicit networks, such as the trafficking of timber, marine life or even drugs and weapons. Drug cartels in Mexico also often run illegal logging operations, sharing transport logistics and laundering illicit timber alongside narcotics, the paper said.

Illicit wildlife networks are converging with broader organised crime, and criminal networks that "are complex, adaptive, and largely invisible, making them notoriously difficult to map, track, and disrupt," said the authors. And this, it added, needs a new approach "to move from enforcement-based, isolated seizures to a predictive understanding of network structure and vulnerability."

The lacunae in understanding mechanisms that feed criminal networks comes in the way of law enforcement, the team added, adding that illegal wildlife trade "comprises global, multibillion-dollar criminal enterprises that threaten biodiversity and elevate the risk of zoonotic disease transfer and emergence".

As for India, primates, turtles, and lizards are the most smuggled illegal species into the country, Dr. Jose told *The Hindu*, primarily through land routes between India and Myanmar. "The criminal network is amoebic in nature: it configures and re-configures to safeguard the business," he said.



For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'



Serious escalation

The new U.S. law on Russian oil imports carries more legal weight

The U.S. Russia Sanctions Act, now signed into law by President Donald Trump, and its resultant impending tariffs, present a new and substantially different escalation of tensions between the U.S. and India. The law provides the U.S. President the authority to levy tariffs of up to 100% on countries such as India that import large quantities of Russian oil and gas. This is more serious than the penal tariffs that Mr. Trump had levied earlier. The escalation last year of reciprocal tariffs to 50% on India's import of Russian oil was based on an Executive Order, and could be rescinded through the same method. This latest Act has been passed by the U.S. Congress and so carries a higher order of legal permanence and authority. Mr. Trump will have to justify in writing to Congress any waiver he wants to provide. The 50% tariffs hit Indian exports to the U.S. hard, but the impact was somewhat mitigated by exporters sharing the cost with their American customers. That was, however, a financially devastating and unsustainable bid to retain customers. Sharing a 100% tariff will be impossible for India's largely micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) exporters. The 100% tariffs are also over and above the 10% 'forced labour' tariffs and the 50% Section 232 tariffs on steel and aluminium. Indian exports to the U.S. will simply become too uncompetitive should these new tariffs come to pass. India has three options before it: cut Russian oil imports, retain those imports and bear the tariffs, or convince the U.S. to implement a low tariff using the "up to 100%" phrasing of the law.

Continuing with Russian oil imports and bearing the tariffs would be a significant blow to India's export ambitions and MSMEs. The U.S. is India's largest export destination, accounting for about 20% of its total goods exports. In any case, historical data have shown that India has usually complied with U.S. pressure to cut oil imports from particular countries, including from Russia, vocal claims of strategic autonomy aside. Finding other sources will be difficult. Russia accounted for more than 51% of India's oil imports as of July 2026, while supplies through the Strait of Hormuz remain constrained. India will have to chivy countries such as Oman to hasten their expansion of alternative ports. The price of oil remains well above \$100 a barrel, meaning finding favourable deals with new suppliers will be increasingly difficult. Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal will have much to do during his planned trip to the U.S. at the end of this month for the G-20 Trade Ministerial. There are still 30 days before the U.S. can levy its tariffs. India's ability to secure a low rate will be a true test of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's friendship with Mr. Trump.

Antidote to drugs

The government must tighten the monitoring of drug production

With the recent bust of a counterfeit medicine racket in Bengaluru, a public policy issue with broad ramifications for health care in the State has emerged. Centered around Bengaluru, relabelled or fake drugs, including cancer drugs, injections used in the ICU, were supplied to more than 90 hospitals and clinics across the State. The lid was blown off this elaborate scam after incidental raids, near Bidadi in Karnataka on August 18, found suspected fake drugs and expired drugs at a farmhouse which was an unlicensed unit. The consignment had a label value of ₹5 crore. Investigators said that the farmhouse was used in an illicit drug operation – involving the repacking of fake and expired drugs as fresh consignments, with altered expiry dates, and as expensive, imported branded drugs – which were then sold at massive discounts. The State later formed a Special Investigation Team to trace the wider network. While exploring the distribution mechanism, investigators found that the network had been supplying these drugs to over 90 hospitals in the State, in cahoots with a pharmacy in Bengaluru, indicating that a network was thriving well before the bust. A few persons have been arrested and the police are on the tail of another who is not in the country at present. The impunity with which the scammers were operating is an indication of the unreliable scrutiny of the quality of drugs in the market. The biggest concern, however, is patient safety, given that these are drugs that can save lives and are marked out for time-sensitive usage. Also being examined are possible inter-State links, as investigators have launched a complete review of the supply chain. The illicit channels through which private hospitals bought and used these drugs, including possible complicity in the private hospital network, are under scrutiny.

With alarming regularity, issues to do with poor quality, spurious, fake or expired drugs hit the headlines in India. For a nation that zealously aspires to become the 'pharmacy of the world', India struggles to match its ambition with adequate and stringent monitoring and quality control systems. The question of drug quality is particularly significant as fake or spurious drugs can cause immediate adverse reactions, lead to severe disabilities, and even death. Recent incidents of contaminated cough syrups causing deaths, not only in India, but across the world, have further highlighted these woefully inadequate systems and consistently dented the pride of the "Make in India" campaign. Irrespective of whether India becomes the pharmacy of the world, there is a pressing need to make sure that drugs and medical supplies made in the country fulfil the highest quality standards.

When the first Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) was passed in 1976, a government of a different political hue was in power from the one that has now proposed the more fierce FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026. But the underlying political apprehensions were similar – the fear that foreign powers could destabilise the country by funding civil society organisations (non-governmental organisations or NGOs). In the present case, there is also an unstated fear of religious conversions by Christian and other religious minorities. The Bill is yet to be enacted because of strong reactions by the Opposition parties and several civil society groups, particularly Christian organisations.

The government claims that the flow of foreign funds into India's NGO sector operates as a vast, intricate and opaque web. Under the banners of development, human rights and social welfare, thousands of crores of unmonitored capital pour into the country every year. Much of this money deliberately bypasses state accounting mechanisms and finds its way into politically charged campaigns, highly selective local advocacy, and aggressive proselytisation and religious conversion networks.

Proposed legislation, the concerns

Under the proposed legislation, if an FCRA certificate is cancelled, surrendered or automatically lapses, foreign contributions and all assets created from them would vest in a government-appointed "designated authority". The organisation can recover the assets if registration is restored within the prescribed period. Permanent vesting will occur only if registration is not restored within that period. The Bill also provides for revision and an appeal to the District Judge.

If a fresh certificate is not obtained within the prescribed period, the assets could be sold or transferred to a government department, with the proceeds going to the Consolidated Fund of India. However, during the provisional-vesting period, restoration of registration results in return of assets and unused foreign contribution.

NGOs, especially Christian organisations, which the government says receive a larger proportion of the funds among religions associations, are worried that the legislation may not be religion-neutral and that, ultimately, the real sufferers would be the beneficiaries served by such charitable organisations, which have established and operate numerous schools, hospitals, old-age care homes and similar institutions. As some leaders from the northeast and tribal areas have pointed out, such institutions are sometimes the largest or only providers of these services in many areas.

Already, the FCRA registrations of 22,496 NGOs



Pushpa Sundar

The author of several books on philanthropy, with the latest title being 'Giving with A Thousand Hands: The Changing Face of Indian Philanthropy'

India's non-governmental organisations must navigate shifting foreign and domestic funding sources

have been cancelled since 2015, leaving about 14,466 active registered associations eligible to receive foreign contributions (Ministry of Home Affairs data, September 2026). In fact, the amounts received are larger than those in 2006-07 (₹12,289.6 crore from private international donors), the last year for which data were available when this writer wrote the book, *Foreign Aid for Indian NGOs: Problem or Solution?* (2010).

So why the protests? The fact is that different sources of funding have a differential impact on organisations and their effectiveness because, as the saying goes, "He who pays the piper calls the tune".

Though in total, the volume of foreign aid to NGOs is small compared with government budgets, and only a small proportion of NGOs receive such aid, it is highly valued because it is not only an alternative source of funding but also more flexible than government funding, with fewer restrictions on how it can be used. It is generally tailored to an NGO's needs through discussions between the NGO and the donor.

The book, *Foreign Aid for Indian NGOs*, which is based desk research and interviews with several NGOs, large and small, suggests that while a few organisations felt that foreign aid had adverse consequences, such as encouraging the adoption of ideas and practices from abroad that were unsuited to Indian conditions, most felt that foreign funds had contributed to India's development and, in particular, to the growth of the voluntary sector. They had brought in new ideas, techniques, technologies and organisational improvements. In the absence of adequate government funding and private philanthropy, foreign aid had played a positive role.

Need for funding diversity

Today, however, given political events in neighbouring countries and elsewhere in the world, and without being privy to the secret sources of information that the government has about the destabilisation role played by foreign money, it is difficult to pass a definitive judgment on the need for and value of foreign aid today.

There can be no doubt that a vibrant and independent civil society is necessary for a healthy democracy and for preventing the abuse of unrestrained political power by any one section of society. Plural sources of funding are also necessary to ensure that civil society is not dependent on any one source.

But equally, one can question whether foreign funds are the only answer to the needs of civil society today. First, the voluntary sector is more developed now. Second, the situation regarding foreign aid itself has changed. Bona fide foreign donors are themselves moving away from giving

to India because of their own economic difficulties and the perception that India, which is aiming to become the world's third-largest economy, no longer needs aid from them.

Third, the domestic non-government funding environment has also improved. According to the Forbes 2026 list, there are 3,332 billionaires in the world, of whom 229 are in India, giving it the third-largest number after the United States and China. The amount they donate to philanthropy has also increased. According to the India Philanthropy Report by Bain & Company, private philanthropy was projected to reach ₹1.43 lakh crore (\$16 billion) in FY 2025. In addition, there is retail giving of about ₹37,000 crore annually.

The downside is that, according to the same report, demand is growing faster than supply, with projections indicating that the gap could reach ₹18 lakh crore (\$210 billion) by 2030.

Moreover, new philanthropists, especially entrepreneurs and technology leaders, are shifting away from traditional areas towards ecosystem building, scientific research, higher education and complex institutional support.

This is undoubtedly good news for social and economic change, but bad news for NGOs delivering traditional education, health and social welfare services.

A glimmer of hope for such NGOs is that, following the Companies Act, 2013, which made corporate social responsibility (CSR) spending compulsory for companies above a certain size, CSR spending by such listed companies was ₹22,563 crore in FY25, up 17.5% (latest CRISIL report).

Since many companies do not have the internal competency to undertake social development, they rely on NGOs as partners. Although many companies are moving into environmental and other emerging areas, many still find the traditional areas of health, education and rural development more meaningful.

A new opportunity

So if, in the ultimate analysis, the government does decide to limit foreign funding, the future need not be bleak if Indian domestic philanthropy steps up to fill the gap.

However, indigenous donors, and the government in particular, must become more responsive to the needs of NGOs, learn from foreign donors some of the practices that made their aid so sought after, and engage in more serious dialogue on funding practices, as distinct from development issues, to improve those practices and address the dissatisfaction on both sides. Ultimately, it is the innate generosity that is dormant in hundreds of dedicated Indians that will change the dynamics of development in India, not foreign aid, which at best can be the cherry on the cake.

India's real rate moment, the cost of delay

India is approaching an uncomfortable turning point in monetary policy. With the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) holding the repo rate at 5.25% while inflation rises, the real policy rate is steadily losing its cushion. Consumer price inflation rose to 4.82% in August, from 4.45% in July, marking the third consecutive month above the RBI's target of 4%. Food inflation is even higher at 5.95%. Core inflation has also risen to around 4.2%, suggesting that price pressures are broadening beyond food.

A view on the real interest rate is not obtained simply by subtracting yesterday's inflation from today's policy rate. Monetary policy operates through expected inflation. If the repo rate remains at 5.25% while inflation expectations move towards 5.25%, the ex-ante real policy rate becomes approximately zero. That is a very different monetary environment from the one in which the real policy rate is comfortably positive.

Closer to zero real rates

India is now much closer to that point than it appeared after the August policy. The RBI maintained a neutral stance, while projecting FY2026-27 inflation at around 5%. However, the latest inflation reading has moved beyond the RBI's projected average trajectory for the year: headline inflation is already 4.82%, while food inflation is 5.95%.

Therefore, if inflationary pressure maintains the current momentum and external pressure aggravates, India could soon find itself in a zero real interest rate environment.

The risks surrounding that trajectory are hardly trivial. The monsoon remains an important source of uncertainty. More importantly, India is confronting a potentially powerful external inflation shock. Renewed conflict in West Asia has disrupted shipping



Saumitra Bhaduri

Professor, Madras School of Economics

The Reserve Bank of India faces a shrinking real-rate cushion as inflation rises and demand remains strong

through the Strait of Hormuz and pushed Brent crude above \$100 a barrel, with prices approaching \$110. The combination of higher oil prices, a weaker rupee and elevated global commodity prices creates a substantially more difficult inflation environment.

Falling real rates are often thought to stimulate demand and credit when the economy is operating below capacity. However, when demand is already healthy, and the inflation shock originates from supply and expectations, the same mechanism can amplify rather than neutralise inflation.

Banking system trends

India's banking system makes the issue even more interesting because the zero real rate is not transmitted symmetrically to borrowers and savers. Bank credit growth stood at 19.1% year-on-year at the end of August and remains exceptionally strong.

Deposits, however, have also surged. Deposit growth reached 17.8% at the end of August, the fastest pace in a decade, partly because of the RBI's special FCNR(B) mobilisation scheme. The increase therefore needs careful interpretation: it does not necessarily indicate that domestic households have suddenly become more willing to hold conventional bank deposits. Instead, much of the increase reflects foreign currency inflows under the special scheme. The credit-deposit ratio was around 80.3% at the end of August.

India is consequently experiencing strong credit demand even as banks compete for stable domestic deposits. Households increasingly have alternatives to bank deposits, including mutual funds and equities. When inflation rises, the real return on conventional deposits becomes less attractive, giving savers a greater incentive to

move towards market-linked assets, gold or other inflation hedges. Empirical evidence from India underscores the importance of this channel. RBI research on the earlier inflation episode found that rising inflation and inflation expectations reduced the real return on household financial savings. During the high-inflation period from 2010 to 2013, real returns on savings instruments became negative and household financial savings weakened, while demand for gold increased substantially. The correlation between gold imports and household inflation expectations was estimated at 0.83 over the period studied.

Therefore, did the RBI miss an opportunity to react earlier? A central bank should not raise rates simply because oil prices have increased. Yet, it must consider the risk that temporary inflation becomes embedded in expectations, wages, prices and credit.

That risk now looks more real. Inflation has remained above 4% for three consecutive months, and August's 4.82% reading was accompanied by a rise in core inflation to around 4.2%, while the one-year OIS rate is around 6%, signalling expectations of some future tightening. At the same time, GDP growth is running at 7.8%, and bank credit is growing at 19.1%. Demand is hardly weak.

The issue is about timing

A 5.25% repo rate may therefore appear restrictive in nominal terms, but offers increasingly little restraint in real terms. The real issue, therefore, is timing. In monetary policy, timing is an instrument in itself. A timely 25-basis-point adjustment may ultimately cost less than a delayed 50-basis-point correction. Importantly, the direction is clear – inflation is moving toward the policy rate while growth and credit remain strong. Perhaps the time has come.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Climate action

India's lower per-capita emissions and progress on renewable capacity are significant, but climate responsibility cannot be discussed only through present-day averages (Front page, September 20). India's rising energy demand, urbanisation and industrial growth require a credible transition strategy. Greater investment in green public transport, energy-efficient buildings, storage technologies and

decentralised renewable power can reduce emissions. In addition, developed countries should provide predictable climate finance and technology access. In the end, a practical approach should combine equity, accountability and measurable targets, rather than competing narratives.

A. Myilsami,
Coimbatore

The real test

A 'bloated' medal tally at

the Asian Games is fine, but it can also create an illusion of sporting progress when several events lack Olympic-level depth. The real test remains the Olympics, where India's performance has repeatedly exposed the gap between regional dominance and global competitiveness. Celebrate medals, certainly, but measure sporting progress by performance against the world's best.

Harsh Pawaria,
Rohtak, Haryana

Immersions and lakes

I wish to highlight the severe environmental toll after idol immersions in Bengaluru's water bodies. The annual immersion of thousands of idols made of Plaster of Paris and painted with synthetic colours releases heavy metals such as lead and mercury into lakes. This can poison aquatic life, damage local flora and fauna, and introduce toxic substances into the human food chain through bioaccumulation,

posing serious health risks. Tradition and nature need not be in conflict. Citizens and organisers must consciously shift to natural clay idols and non-toxic colours to ensure that our celebrations preserve rather than pollute the environment.

Sowmiya Devi Rammohan,
Bengaluru

Dumping festival idols into our local lakes is getting out of hand. These huge structures are covered in

toxic chemical paints and made of Plaster of Paris, which pollutes the water. If we want to save our shrinking lakes and water bodies, the government must completely ban chemical paints and non-biodegradable materials. Our celebrations should not end up destroying the environment.

Shreshya Bhardwaj,
Bengaluru

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Missing measure in India's magnet mission

Bridging this measurement gap is not an academic exercise; it is an industrial imperative.

While India is steadily building its manufacturing capabilities, that expansion remains deeply embedded in China-centric, import-dependent supply chains

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of Karnataka taluks to be declared drought-hit

200 More than 200 taluks across Karnataka are likely to be included in the drought-affected list as the government assesses them in phases based on prescribed criteria and ground-truthing, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara said on Sunday. PTI

Ambedkar statues vandalised in Uttar Pradesh

151 Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday said 151 statues of B.R. Ambedkar were damaged across 72 districts of Uttar Pradesh during the BJP's rule, but only 14 arrests have been made so far. He alleged that the vandalism was done deliberately. PTI

Record-high average French diesel prices amid oil disruption

2.41 in €. French diesel prices hit a fresh record on Sunday, as the West Asia war disrupts oil supplies. The price per litre stood at €2.41 euros (\$2.76 dollars). Prices have been soaring across the world after the U.S. and Israel launched their war against Iran in February. PTI

Number of miners in Nigeria who died in detention

37 Thirty-seven young men were found dead inside a crowded cell in Minna, the capital of central Niger state, on Thursday. Survivors recounted being crammed in the cell with poor ventilation, and one said a substance that stung their throats and noses was sprayed into the cell. AFP

Number of people missing in Nepal flash floods

6,000 Search operations continued in Nepal on Sunday for around 6,000 people who are still unaccounted for nearly four weeks after the devastating flash floods that killed more than 1,400. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

The copyright stakes in the EU FTA

Draft India-EU FTA's copyright provisions could require changes to India's Copyright Act and weaken existing exceptions for students, archivists, Internet service providers; negotiators must seek to restore the WIPO Copyright Treaty to the National Treatment clause and preserve the country's digital copyright flexibilities

ECONOMIC NOTES

Zakir Thomas
Biswajit Dhar

Recently, the European Commission formally requested EU member states to approve the signing and conclusion of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement. Details of the commitments the two partners have accepted in the covered areas, including intellectual property (IP), have also been revealed. The draft IP Chapter includes detailed provisions on copyright that require close examination of their impact on India's digital policy landscape.

The structural asymmetry
Our assessment is that the provisions in the draft IP Chapter would necessitate amendments to India's Copyright Act, 1957, which is in conformity with international IP treaties including the WIPO Copyright Treaty (WCT) and the Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS) Agreement. Though the current provisions explicitly affirm the commitments of both parties to these IP treaties, they omit the WCT from the crucial National Treatment clause (Article 10.8).

It may be noted that the WCT was specifically adopted for the protection of works and the rights of their authors in the digital environment, particularly software and databases, while also providing for technological protection measures (TPMs). Excluding the WCT from the National Treatment provisions of the IP Chapter implies that the limitations on or exceptions to copyright for digital works that the WCT provides (Article 10) would henceforth be unavailable to India.

Limitations and exceptions under the FTA (Article 10.21) include a narrow "three-step test", borrowed from EU copyright statutes. If the extant exceptions in India's Copyright Act are not preserved, foreign rightsholders could challenge the exceptions for digital works available under Section 52 (or "fair dealing"), including transient or



GETTY IMAGES

incidental storage of a work or performance purely in the technical process of electronic transmission or communication to the public under Article 10.11 of the FTA, subjecting them to civil and criminal remedies.

The danger becomes more apparent when read alongside Footnote 1 of Article 10.8(1), which expands "protection" to cover enforcement measures against the circumvention of TPMs (Article 10.18) and Rights Management Information (Article 10.19). By including WCT's enforcement mandates among the binding obligations while excluding this treaty from the National Treatment exceptions, the draft IP Chapter abandons the WCT's principles, namely, balancing authors' rights with public interest exceptions in education and research, while providing a rigid enforcement mandate.

This structural imbalance directly threatens Section 65A of India's Copyright Act, 1957, which deals with TPMs. Section 65A(2) provides exceptions under which technological protection can be circumvented, particularly for the purposes permitted therein. Thus, if a student or researcher bypasses a digital lock to perform a lawful act protected under Section 52, no criminal liability attaches.

Chilling effect on classrooms, labs
The real-world consequences of this legal

shift will be borne by India's academic and educational institutions. Under Sections 52(1)(ab) and (ac) of the Copyright Act, engineering students and security researchers are legally permitted to observe, test, and reverse-engineer software to foster interoperability or uncover critical security vulnerabilities.

Yet, modern software is almost universally guarded by encryption and digital access controls.

Under a strict anti-circumvention regime, a computer science student breaking a digital lock to inspect code for system compatibility or security flaws could be transformed overnight into a legal offender. Similarly, public libraries and academic archives face unprecedented risks. In an era when historical documents, literature, and research are increasingly distributed in digital formats burdened by Digital Rights Management (DRM), librarians depend on format-shifting to archive out-of-print works and preserve fragile collections. A strict anti-circumvention rule would strip archivists of the legal right to bypass digital locks for preservation.

Furthermore, as higher education relies more on electronic materials, paywalls and DRM controls could effectively overwrite the public interest protections established by Indian courts in landmark rulings such as the DU Photocopy Case.

Threat to Internet service providers

Under India's Copyright Act (Sections 52(1)(b) and (c)), Internet service providers (ISPs) and digital intermediaries are shielded from liability for the temporary, transient copies created in RAM and server caches during routine data routing. The notice and takedown regime established under Rule 75 of the Copyright Rules, 2013 relies on these statutory safe harbours.

The FTA draft undermines this framework by granting rightsholders an exclusive, unqualified right over all "temporary or permanent" reproductions under Article 10.11(a), in contravention of the Agreed Statements to Article 8 and Article 10 of the WCT, which exempt transient network copies from copyright liability. Exclusion of the WCT from the National Treatment exception could, therefore, leave ISPs at risk of legal challenge, with EU rightsholders exposing Indian intermediaries to systemic liability.

By agreeing to the draft text, the negotiators seem to have gone beyond the Indian Parliament's mandate as reflected in the Copyright Act, 1957. Left uncorrected, this would oblige Parliament to remove the exceptions covering digital works in the Act, regardless of whether the user was engaging in legitimate, lawful research.

A call for recalibration

India's policy flexibilities must not be traded away in bilateral trade bargains. Our negotiators must insist on targeted revisions. They should press to re-insert the WCT into the National Treatment Clause. India's rise as a digital powerhouse rests on a foundation of open access to knowledge, robust educational inquiry, and independent technical research. While deepening trade ties with the EU is crucial, this must not be at the expense of our digital sovereignty or our students' right to learn. Negotiators must ensure the availability of statutory flexibilities in the copyright domain that keep Indian innovation alive. (Zakir Thomas is the IPR Chair at National Law School of India University, Bengaluru and Biswajit Dhar was the IPR Chair Professor at JNU)

THE GIST

The draft IP Chapter omits the WIPO Copyright Treaty from the National Treatment clause while retaining its enforcement mandates on technological protection measures and rights management information

A strict anti-circumvention regime could expose students and security researchers to liability for bypassing digital locks while reverse-engineering software or examining security vulnerabilities

Public libraries and academic archives could face restrictions on format-shifting digital works, while Internet service providers could face liability over temporary copies created during routine data routing

What does Tulu's new official language status mean?

How will the new status change the use of Tulu in administration? Is the Cabinet's decision enough?

Raviprasad Kamila

The story so far:

Karnataka government, in its Cabinet meeting held in Mangaluru on September 18, decided to accord the additional official (administrative) language status to Tulu, which is commonly spoken in Dakshina Kannada district, southern parts of Udupi district in Karnataka, and northern parts of Kasaragod district in Kerala. While making the announcement, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said the status will apply to administrative matters in the two districts. The government will release ₹82 lakh annually for translation, training and language usage purposes.

How will the decision help people?
B. Shivarama Shetty, former Project Director, Centre of Excellence for Studies

in Classical Kannada, Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL), Mysuru, said that elected representatives can speak in Tulu at gram sabhas of gram panchayats, taluk panchayats, and zilla panchayats meetings. It also applies to urban local body meetings such as city corporation council, city municipal council and town municipal council meetings. The government circulars and orders issued in the two districts should also contain Tulu. People can submit applications to government departments in Tulu. This will make officials who do not know Tulu depend on translations, translators, or learn the basics of Tulu.

When did the government move to grant official status to Tulu begin?
When the BJP government was in power, the then Minister for Kannada and Culture, V. Sunil Kumar, on January 30, 2023, formed a committee headed by M.

Mohan Alva, Chairman, Alva's Education Foundation, Moodbidri, Dakshina Kannada, to study and submit a report on declaring Tulu as the second official language of Karnataka.

The committee was asked to submit its report to the government in a week. According to Mr. Kumar, the BJP government could not grant official language status to Tulu because the model code of conduct for the 2023 Assembly elections in Karnataka was declared on March 29, 2023, and the BJP lost power in the elections.

Later, the Congress government took over in Karnataka. It appointed a committee led by K. M. Gayatri, Director of Kannada and Culture, to study the procedures adopted by the Andhra Pradesh government to grant additional language status to Urdu.

This committee visited Andhra Pradesh on January 19 and 20, 2026 and studied

how Urdu is being used in administration. The committee submitted its report to the Karnataka government on March 4, against the backdrop of the move to declare Tulu as the additional official language.

Is the Cabinet's decision enough?

Article 345 of the Constitution allows each State legislature to choose one or more regional languages or Hindi as the official language for its official work. It says: "Subject to the provisions of articles 346 and 347, the Legislature of a State may by law adopt any one or more of the languages in use in the State or Hindi as the language or languages to be used for all or any of the official purposes of that State."

Section 2 of the Karnataka Official Language Act, 1963 states that Kannada is the official language.

Some law graduates say that if Karnataka is to implement the Cabinet's decision, it will have to amend the Karnataka Official Language Act to incorporate Tulu as an additional administrative language in Dakshina Kannada and Udupi districts. Once the amendment is approved by the appropriate authority, the Governor, the government will issue a notification, following which the Cabinet's decision will come into force. The governments of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana followed

the same procedure – amending their respective language laws – to declare Urdu as the second official language of their States.

How is this language introduced in academics?

Tulu is taught as the third optional language in schools, from Class 6 to Class 10, in Dakshina Kannada and Udupi districts. It was first introduced for Class 6 in the 2010-11 academic year. It is not being taught as a subject in pre-university and degree classes. Mangalore University introduced a two-year Tulu postgraduation programme in its erstwhile University Evening College (now closed down) in 2018-19. The programme was wound up from the academic year 2024-25, citing a lack of students in double digits who applied to join the programme.

Is it an independent language?

The Registrar General and Census Commissioner has recognised Tulu as an independent language of India ever since the department was established, and the Census Report gives statistics about Tulu speakers as a separate linguistic community.

It is treated as an important non-scheduled language of India. But it is not included in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution.

CACHE



GETTY IMAGES

How EU plans to keep children under 15 away from social media

EU is considering age-based rules that would restrict children's access to social media, video-sharing platforms, AI chatbots and online games; the proposal would place new responsibilities on technology companies, including age verification, safer recommendation systems, parental controls

John Xavier

The European Union is considering a major change to the way children access the internet, and it could affect everything from kids using Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, and various AI chatbots.

Under a proposal being prepared by the European Commission, per a report by *Reuters*, children under 15 could face restrictions on creating and using accounts across a wide range of digital services.

The EU's plan is part of the EU Kids Act, which is aimed at making digital services safe for children, and it comes at a time when governments around the world are grappling with growing concerns over how digital platforms affect children's well-being.

Social media platforms have come under increasing scrutiny over how they design their applications to be addictive and serve harmful content that is powered by recommendation algorithms.

Rather than imposing one rule on every child, the EU proposal would create different levels of access based on age.

Children aged 15 and above would be able to create their own accounts.

For children aged 13 and 14, access to social media and video-sharing platforms would require parents to get involved.

Parents could create introductory accounts for their children, with restrictions on contacts and time spent on the platforms.



For children between 3 and 12, accounts would be controlled entirely by parents. Their access would be limited to services considered suitable for children and required to meet stronger safety standards.

The proposal could potentially ban access to digital platforms for children under 3.

The exact rules could still change before the plan is formally presented and negotiated with EU governments and the European Parliament.

One of the more significant aspects of the proposal is its broad scope.

Beyond social platforms

The rules would not stop at platforms like Facebook, Instagram, TikTok and YouTube. They would also cover AI chatbots and online gaming platforms, bringing a much wider part of children's digital lives under the proposed framework.

The proposal is being framed based on the idea that children's internet use is no longer limited to scrolling through social feeds. They text AI chatbots, play games online, watch videos that are

Tech platforms have been arguing that they already have safeguards in place, as major social media applications have set a minimum sign-up age of 13; but critics have complained that age limits on paper are not enough

algorithmically recommended and chat with other users across numerous platforms.

The bloc's views on the overall digital ecosystem could make the path ahead for social platforms and consumer-facing AI applications a bit difficult, as they will have to take up new responsibilities.

More responsibilities for platforms Platforms could be required to reduce features designed to encourage engagement and limit exposure to harmful recommendation feeds. They would also need to make it easier for children to report inappropriate content.

They will need to provide parents with stronger tools to control what their children see and how long they spend on their services.

Age verification could become an important requirement as social media and video-sharing platforms would need to verify a user's age when a new account is created.

Online gaming platforms would have to check age before allowing children to download games.

Apart from features that control the

use of these applications, tech companies could also be expected to pay for the system, as the bloc could propose a supervisory fee to fund regulatory enforcement and oversight.

Child and the digital ecosystem

The EU's proposal comes amid a growing clamour of voices wanting clear guardrails over a child's relationship with the digital ecosystem.

Tech platforms have been arguing that they already have safeguards in place, as major social media applications have set a minimum sign-up age of 13.

But critics have complained that age limits on paper are not enough if platforms cannot reliably determine how old their users actually are.

The EU's proposed approach would shift more of the responsibility onto technology companies, while giving parents greater control over younger children's online activities. This could mean fewer ways for children to sign up for popular social applications on their own.

Tech firms, on the other hand, will have to operate more carefully in the bloc as rules governing how they verify users, design their platforms and recommend content to younger audiences will structurally change.

This proposal still has a long way to go before becoming law. The European Commission will need to work with EU member states and the European Parliament, and the final rules could look different from the current draft.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Electronic band Depeche Mode released their first music video, *'Just Can't Get Enough'*, in 1981. Identify the following acclaimed electronic music videos from the hints below

Mohammed Hidhayat

QUESTION 1

A man with a realistic dog's head and one leg in a cast wanders through New York City with a boombox.

QUESTION 2

A gymnast, played by Sofia Coppola, walks into a packed school sports hall to face a favoured rival.

QUESTION 3

A Frenchman wakes up, gets ready, and arrives in his customized car to compete in a car-audio

decibel contest.

QUESTION 4

A kid on a metro discovers that the music player in his hand can pause, rewind, and fast-forward the real world. A classic!

QUESTION 5

Shot in black and white, two men walk towards the camera as their T-shirts come alive with colourful typography.

QUESTION 6

A group of children with telekinetic powers escape a facility, test their abilities, and wait to join the outside world.



Visual Question:

Identify the music video from the screengrab shown. It won the Film Craft Grand Prix at Cannes Lions 2017. ICONOCLAST VIA YOUTUBE

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:

- It is well known that the Asian Games debuted in New Delhi in 1951. What is the only other time India has played host to the Games? **Ans: 1982 in New Delhi**
 - India is the fifth-most successful country at the Games. In which Games did it cross the 100-medal mark with 107? **Ans: Hangzhou 2023**
 - The most successful Indian athlete at the Games has 11 medals. Who and in which Games did the legend win four golds? **Ans: The peerless P.T. Usha and Seoul 1986**
 - Mohamed Anas Imran Beg, Declan Marshall Gonsalves and Quimcy Dsouza are representing India in which sport that is making its debut in 2026? **Ans: Teqball**
 - In which sport has India been dominant? **Ans: Kabaddi**
 - Which sport follows athletics for the most medals for India with 80 including 16 gold. **Ans: Shooting**
 - Who is set to become the first Indian sportsperson to feature at seven Asian Games? **Ans: Joshna Chinappa (squash)**
- Visual: Name this swimmer. **Ans: Sachin Nag (100m freestyle)**
- Early Birds:** Prem Nath Tiwari | K.N. Viswanathan | Prem Raj P. | M. Suresh Kumar



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

Rakesh chose couch-surfing during his trip

My boss is proof that handsome is as handsome does

S. Upendran

"I don't know why Vrinda agreed to marry Ganpat. He's not very good looking and he..."

"True, but he's a wonderful person. Very kind. You know what they say, 'handsome is as handsome does'."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"It's a roundabout way of saying good looks don't really matter. An individual's worth is determined by how he is with others – how he treats others."

"In other words, judge someone by his actions – what he does, and how he treats people. Looks can be deceiving."

"Whenever my grandmother caught my brother standing in front of the mirror for a long time, she used to say, 'Handsome is as handsome does.'"

"My boss is very good looking, but he's mean to all those who work under him. Handsome is as handsome does, I guess."

"One can also say 'pretty is as pretty does'! Priya might not be much to look at, but she's a very helpful person. You know what they say, pretty is as pretty does."

"That's true. Sheba tells me that Rakesh is taking a couple of months off." "Yes, he's going to be doing some amount of travelling. He's spending a couple of months in Thailand and Vietnam."

"Either he has a lot of money or he knows a lot of people in those countries."

"Neither. He plans to do couch-surfing!"

"Couch-surfing?"

"The term was originally used for international travelling. When you do 'couch-surfing', you stay in a stranger's home for free."

"Really? That's a great way to travel."

"But you don't get the normal convenience or comfort of a hotel. You may be asked to sleep on a couch or the floor."

"Which explains why it's called 'couch-surfing', I guess."

"Exactly! Although you get to stay free of charge, you might be expected to help with the household chores."

"But how do you find a place to couch-surf?"

"Families which allow you to couch-surf advertise online. Rakesh's brother did a month of couch-surfing in Brazil last year."

"A family allowed him to stay with them for a month? That was..."

"When you couch-surf, you don't stay in a place for too long. You keep moving. Couch-surfing is something you probably do when you're young."

"I'm planning to visit Sri Lanka in December. Maybe I should couch-surf and see what the experience is like."

"Nowadays, the term has begun to be used when you're travelling within your own country and staying with people you may or may not know."

"So, you can couch-surf at your friend's place?"

"Your friend's place or a relative's. Mohan and I are going to be spending a couple of weeks in Mumbai looking for a job. We'll be couch-surfing at the homes of our former classmates."

"Our flat wasn't ready. We were forced to couch-surf in several houses for over three weeks."

"Sounds good."

upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Aggrandisement:

the act of increasing the wealth, prestige, power or scope of something

Synonyms: advancement, preferment, glorification, promotion

Usage: *The award was not meant for personal aggrandisement.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/aggrandisement

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

Are kirana clusters the future of inclusive retail?



Win win: The retailer association can employ a shared pool of delivery agents, vehicles. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

R. Sathyanarayanan

Offering speed and convenience, quick commerce is rapidly transforming the urban retail landscape through agile logistics. Meanwhile, in a sign of growing anxiety in the grassroots retail community,the Khasi Hills Autonomous District Council of Meghalaya has reportedly denied quick commerce platform Blinkit a trading licence over fears it might endanger livelihoods dependent on the region's 4,000 grocery stores (kiranans). Though a valid concern, the solution need not necessarily be to stop the advance of platforms but to build new capabilities for kiranans to achieve successful coexistence. Can cooperation offer kiranans a practical logistics response? A cooperative kirana delivery cluster experiment in hyperlocal logistics could be imagined with around 20 kirana store members within a 3km radius in a dense neighbourhood. Each member-store shall remain independent with its customer base, pricing, credit relationships and individual identity intact, while collaborating on ordering and delivery.

Customised app
Through WhatsApp or another customised app, a customer selects regular store and places an order. If the store cannot fulfill it, the order will move to another member store in the cluster. The retailer association employs a shared pool of delivery personnel and vehicles to deliver orders within 20-30 minutes. The cluster development model designed by the United Nations Industrial Development Organization for small and medium enterprises (SMEs) offers useful lessons. The issue with SMEs is not just the size but also the isolation. A small store cannot individually invest in technology, logistics systems, and professional service design. But a 'coopetition cluster' – rival companies competing and cooperating simultaneously to grow the overall market – allows them to share capabilities while remaining independent. The Trichy engineering cluster is an exciting example. Years ago, the micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) located near the public sector company BHEL had formed the BHEL Small Scale Industries Association. They went on to create the BHEL Industrial Development and Service Society to collectively purchase and distribute consumables to members at competitive rates. At a global level, the Associated Wholesale Grocers, Wakefern, and SPAR are examples of how a retailer cooperative model can facilitate common procurement, distribution and technology. While pool procurement for kiranans may appear far-fetched at the moment, they can explore backend cooperation for services such as deliveries. (The writer is Sundram Fasteners Associate Professor of Marketing, IFMR Graduate School of Business at Krea University)

Onida rewired: the devil is in the detail; the path forward is not easy

Neighbour's envy 5.0. Onida again bets on its iconic 'devil' as it attempts a fifth comeback, but can nostalgia alone tempt younger buyers? the generation Onida needs to win over may neither remember the devil (Onida's time-tested icon) nor view television as a traditional broadcast box

NEWS ANALYSIS

Amit Vijay Mohile

A known devil is better than an unknown one is the common saying. For Onida, familiarity may no longer be enough. Its 'devil' may need to take an unfamiliar turn as a crusader taking on problems appliance buyers have learnt to tolerate – from hard water damaging washing machines to air-conditioners forcing households to buy separate heaters during winter, and obscure warranties and repeat repairs. That would give a contemporary cause to a mascot introduced in 1984 with the tagline “Neighbour's Envy, Owner's Pride”, but repeatedly retired, revived, and reinvented since. Harish Bijoor, brand strategy specialist and founder of Harish Bijoor Consults Inc., argues Onida's devil needs precisely such a role for a new generation. “Make the devil the Tukaram Mundhe of consumer durables activism,” Bijoor says, invoking the bureaucrat known for taking on entrenched systems. His argument: Don't make the devil Onida's salesman; make him the consumer's advocate. Sanjay Sarma, principal consultant and founder of



Back in the reckoning: Srivastava is trying to make an established brand matter. BIJOY GHOSH

SSARMA Consults, agrees these are the “newer problems” that Onida could own, almost “fix the plumbing for your life”. **Origins in envy** Giraj Sharma, co-founder of BehindTheMoon Consultants, who joined Onida in 1985 and spent 12 years heading marketing, recalls colour TVs were scarce enough for families to gather at neighbours' homes that had them. The envy existed before the advertising did; Onida's tagline captured that tension, and the devil gave it a face. Onida's brand manual now moves him “From Envy to Intelligence”, replacing “I want what they have” with “Maybe there is a smarter choice”. The stakes are bigger

Under Onida 5.0, its devil is recast as an “intelligent provocateur”, darker, sharper, and more premium – one who “never follows”, “never attacks”, and “never boasts without reason”. **The new test** But while Onida has defined how its resurrected devil should behave, it's less clear which consumer problem he is out to solve. For “Onida Rewired” the company has raised ₹149.52 crore, exited contract manufacturing and renamed MIRC Electronics as Onida Electronics. It is widening its retail reach, pushing 100-inch QD mini-LED TVs and smart inverter ACs, and targeting over 5% of the premium TV and AC markets in three years. Its management has spoken of increasing revenue fivefold over five years, implying about ₹3,300

This festival season there are fewer plane seats

Rohit Vaid

It's the time of year when crores of Indians pack their bags for get-togethers with loved ones to celebrate a string of festivals, or head to a tourist destination for rest and recreation. At the start of the season, extending from September to January, domestic air ticket prices are ruling above last year levels even as fares have eased from August, offering travellers partial relief. Data shared by Cleartrip showed the average domestic airfares for September were 12-20% higher compared with a year ago, while they have slid 5-10% compared with August. ixigo's year-on-year comparison showed the average one-way fare on the Delhi-Hyderabad sec-



Festive woes: The fare increases would need to cover both higher ATF costs and the currency depreciation. VELANKANNI RAJ B

tor rose 74% to ₹8,253 from ₹4,739. The Delhi-Goa fare increased 47% to ₹7,896 from ₹5,377, while the Delhi-Bengaluru fare rose similarly to ₹9,199 from ₹6,273. The Mumbai-Kolkata fare increased 43% to ₹8,094 from ₹5,653. The fares are for bookings made 15-20 days before departure.

The comparison also showed the Delhi-Pune fare rose 35% to ₹7,150 from ₹5,293, while the Delhi-Mumbai fare increased 21% to ₹6,456 from ₹5,317. The Mumbai-Bengaluru fare rose 45% to ₹5,884 from ₹4,066. **Fewer seats** The higher fares come at a

time of fewer scheduled seats in the domestic market. According to consolidated industry data from aviation analytics firm Cirium, scheduled seat capacity for September was down 5.3% year-on-year to 1.49crore. This implies 8.32 lakh fewer scheduled seats compared with September last year. The number of scheduled flights is down by 8.5% to 83,515 from 91,287 – namely 7,772 truncated services. Meanwhile, capacity measured in available seat kilometres (ASKs) is lower by 6.2%. The Cirium figures describe scheduled capacity for September, rather than flights actually operated or passengers carried. Sequentially, the number of scheduled domestic flights for September are

4% lower compared with 87,035 in August. Seat capacity is also down 4% from 1.55crore, while ASKs are lower by 4.7%. Furthermore, the scheduled seat capacity in September is fewer by about 6.29 lakh than in August. The industry totals do not establish whether capacity has fallen on all routes where fares have risen. **Jet fuel price rise** For those planning to travel during the festival season, capacity additions will be a key factor shaping ticket prices, an industry insider pointed out, adding fares through the year-end would depend on the extent of additions by airlines. Other industry observers said elevated jet fuel prices linked to the West Asia crisis and lower

domestic capacity contributed to the annual rise in airfares. However, a senior executive with a leading airline told *businessline* the increase in airfares would not be enough to offset the sector's operating losses. Another senior aviation executive said the weakening rupee against the dollar was adding to the cost pressure. The executive estimated that around 70% of airline costs, including aviation turbine fuel (ATF), is denominated in, or linked to the dollar. In addition, the fare increases would need to cover both higher ATF costs and the currency depreciation to enable airlines to maintain bottom lines at last year's level, the executive said. (The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Brands return to the fold: yielding to classic design precepts

OPINION

Harish Bhat

Earlier this month, Apple unveiled its first foldable iPhone, the Duo. The starting price in India is nearly ₹3 lakh. Advanced versions are priced more than ₹4 lakh. The two questions on many minds are: “Why does anybody need a foldable phone?” And “Why would consumers pay such a huge price for this device?” Foldable phones have generally not been very popular. But I do know people who use them with passion and pride, and show them around. For instance, someone who uses another foldable phone, the Samsung Galaxy X

Fold8, recently told me how the large screen enables him to work seamlessly while travelling. It is, therefore, likely the iPhone Duo too may soon have its band of avid users in India. Many may feel it enhances productivity and ease of use. Others may see it as a marker of status. The world may soon be split between the “Duolites” and the rest of us. **Umbrellas, notebooks** But if this makes you think foldable products are elitist, you are mistaken. The original foldable product is the umbrella – a common man's product. Unless an umbrella folds, how can you carry it or store it conveniently? In fact, there is even the four-fold umbrella, which



Widening offerings: The new foldable iPhone Duo is displayed during an Apple event in California. AFP

collapses into four sections, making it ultra-compact. It can easily fit into a small purse or a trouser pocket. So, you can carry an umbrella in your pocket and display a foldable

phone proudly in hand, which is the reverse of what many of us now do. Another product where we take the fold for granted is the laptop or notebook computer. Desktop

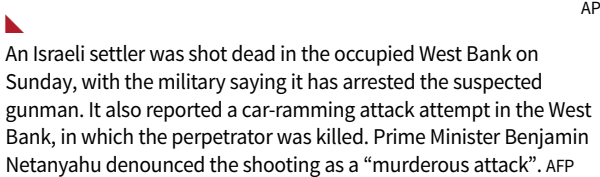
computers were not foldable and the first few notebook computers too did not fold. The clamshell design in use today, where the screen rests flat on the keyboard once folded, was

first introduced by a brand named Grid Compass in 1982. It was initially expensive and primarily used only by NASA during early space shuttle missions. Today, it is the default design, enabling us to carry our laptops with ease. **Chairs and Swiss knives** Then there is folding furniture, including chairs and tables, which have been around for decades. A bed that folds into a compact sofa saved space in homes. I own a Swiss knife and this innovative product always amazes me – multiple knives, scissors and other tools fold into its beautiful, lacquered red handle, and sit on top of each other in a stack, which forms the heart of this design. The Swiss knife

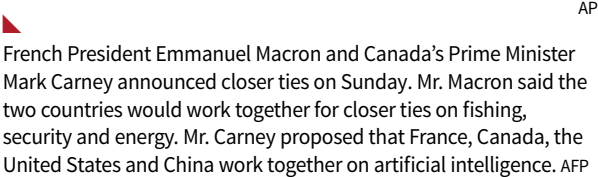
is a great multitasker, and a true champion of folded products. From Japan comes the art of origami – folding paper to create interesting and beautiful designs. Having nothing to do with convenience, the folded products here offer us art and beauty in our daily lives. And, let me not forget books, where the pages fold so elegantly over a spine, enabling us to open and close the book smoothly. **The benefits** The range of folding products bring home the functional benefits of a fold. Sheer convenience in the case of the umbrella or laptop computer, versatility in the Swiss knife and a wider screen in the case of a fol-

dable mobile phone. There are also the emotive benefits. A four-fold umbrella in your pocket is quiet reassurance that you will not get wet. A folding bed makes us feel good about being a gracious host when guests stay over. Origami makes us feel beautiful. And, to return to where we began, a small foldable phone can be a big marker of status. So, will the iPhone Duo be a big hit in India? My view is yes, because both the functional and emotional benefits of this device are irresistible for a clear segment of our population. The actual answer will, of course, unfold over the next few months. (Harish Bhat is a curious marketer and bestselling author)

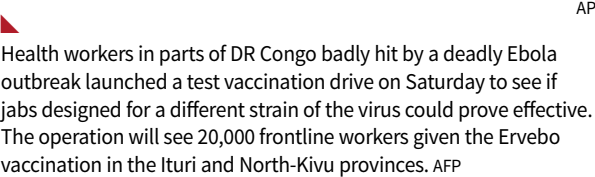
Suspect held after Israeli settler shot dead in occupied West Bank



Macron, Carney announce closer ties in security, energy and fishing

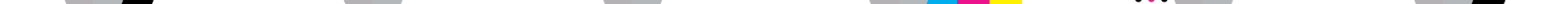


Frontline workers get jabs as Ebola vaccine trial commences in Congo



Senior Taiwan official embarks on rare visit to China for APEC event



CM YK  A IN-X



Petronila Munoz points to the plot of land where the tech hub could be built in Capas, Tarlac province. AFP

Philippine tribe in limbo over U.S.-led tech hub initiative

Agence France-Presse
CAPAS

Tribal leader Petronila Munoz walked across the sweeping Philippine grasslands she has called home for generations, uncertain about its future, as a sprawling tech hub for a U.S.-led initiative takes shape.

With little information and no prior consultation, the indigenous chieftain said her Aeta Hunguey tribe was uncertain how much of their land could be affected. “There’s still no clarity,” Ms. Munoz told AFP inside the tribe’s traditional meeting hall. “What will happen to us? That’s our biggest question.”

The Philippines has designated a 1,620-hectare site in New Clark City in Tarlac province for a manufacturing hub to produce high-end components for use in artificial intelligence data centres.

The project has a long timeline. No tenants have been confirmed. For about 1,000 Aetas, the prospect of displacement is already here.

In July, they received a letter from the Bases Conversion and Development Authority (BCDA) warning that the project “could affect your occupied lands”.

Ms. Munoz said visiting BCDA employees told them to leave by December and relocate to an area about 16 km from their current home.

Ms. Munoz said the BCDA has offered them just 30 pesos (\$0.48) per square metre for their lands, an offer all declined.

The BCDA declined to address specific questions about the Aetas’ situation and rejected a freedom of information request for the site’s official boundary map and geospatial data.

New party now a front runner in Israel polls amid Netanyahu’s waning appeal

Yashar leads in opinion polls as its leader Gadi Eisenkot’s popularity among voters eclipses that of the Prime Minister; Eisenkot bats for strategic wars over endless ones, and concurs with Netanyahu on matter such as two-state solution and Iran; the PM battles charges of corruption and negligence

Sambavi Parthasarathy

As Israel gears up for its parliamentary elections on October 27, a one-year-old party has emerged as a significant contender. The Yashar (Hebrew for ‘straight’) party has garnered widespread support as per the opinion polls reported by Israeli media outlets, some of which place the party ahead of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s Likud party.

Opinion polls

In most projections, Yashar led with at least 20 of 120 seats in Knesset, Israel’s parliament, while Likud trailed behind. Channel 12 News and Channel 13 News put Yashar at 23 and 22 seats, while Likud followed with 20 and 19 seats respectively. According to the poll published by Maariv, Yashar was projected to win 25 seats while Likud trailed with 19. While the polls did not point to a clear winner, Yashar consistently emerged as a leading party.

Gadi Eisenkot, who leads the centrist party and is a former member of Prime Minister Netanyahu’s cabinet, projects himself as everything that Mr. Netanyahu is not. Mr. Eisenkot, who held his first electoral meeting less than three months ago on June 30, is now as popular as

the Prime Minister.

This growing support for Yashar and its leader is strongly buttressed by the public sentiment following the October 7, 2023, Hamas attack, which has emerged as one of the central issues for voters. While Mr. Eisenkot has promised strategic wars rather than endless ones while maintaining Israeli sentiments on Palestine’s two-state solution and Iran, Mr. Netanyahu is losing his appeal amid mounting challenges, including corruption charges, allegations of negligence regarding warnings of the Hamas attack, diplomatic tensions and declining ratings.

According to Dahlia Scheindlin, a policy fellow at the Mitvim Institute and a strategy consultant and public opinion expert for political and social campaigns in Israel, “The main aspect driving Yashar is the voters – the same specific constituency that is centrist-leaning right, security-minded, patriotic, but not far-right or extremist in Israeli terms. They supported Gantz in 2023-24, then they supported Bennett in 2025, then Eisenkot seemed like a credible, fresh politician who could win, so they shifted to him. After that, the figure of Eisenkot, a trustworthy former Chief of Staff and a bereaved father (and uncle) who projects something



Winning votes: Gadi Eisenkot (centre) has a familiar appeal that Israelis can sympathise with: one of a soldier who has served his country and has lost a son and two nephews to the war. AFP

ing straightforward (as per his party name), by contrast to Netanyahu.”

She added that the appeal cannot be attributed to just his promise of an inquiry commission into the events of October 7, 2023, as most parties seem to promise the same.

A bereaved soldier

Mr. Eisenkot served in the Israel Defence Forces (IDF) for 41 years. The 66-year-old made his debut in politics in 2022 alongside Benny Gantz, another former Army chief. Four days after the October 7 Hamas attack, he was invited by Mr. Netanyahu to join his war

cabinet, where he served till June 2024. He was and continues to be a strong critic of Mr. Netanyahu’s handling of the Gaza war.

Besides his political stances, Mr. Eisenkot also has a familiar appeal that Israelis, who have borne the brunt of a prolonged conflict for nearly three years, can sympathise with: one of a soldier who has served his country and has lost a son and two nephews to the war.

While these factors connect him with the public, he still echoes Mr. Netanyahu when it comes to select foreign policies. He shares Mr. Netanyahu’s senti-

ments with respect to matters such as the two-state solution and views on Iran. That is, irrespective of who comes to power, Gaza and West Bank are bound to see little change.

His party’s 10-point goals, published on its online platform, carry a focus on both national and domestic issues. The mentioned goals include ensuring the existence of the state of Israel as the national home of the Jewish people while preserving its character as a Jewish and democratic state and strengthening Israel’s national security and positioning it as a strong re-

gional power. Its domestic goals include strengthening the IDF, ensuring that every citizen serves in the military or national service, reducing social gaps within the country, and strengthening governance and solving economic issues such as the high cost of living.

Obstacles for Eisenkot

The road ahead for the party is not without obstacles. “Both coalition math and Eisenkot’s inexperience will be a problem for the coalition-building/bargaining phase, and for keeping such a coalition together,” explained Ms. Scheindlin.

Mr. Eisenkot currently lags in international appeal which Netanyahu commands while dealing with foreign media. Regarded as the author of ‘Dahiyeh Doctrine’ – an Israeli military doctrine that calls for the use of disproportionate force and deliberate targeting of civilians and infrastructure – Mr. Eisenkot has previously earned Israel international condemnation.

Ms. Scheindlin commented, “He can if he chooses to, and there will be a great deal of expectation and anticipation if he replaces Netanyahu. But he will also have to take steps regarding the Palestinians that will earn criticism at home, and he will have to learn how to face that without caving in.”

Rapper’s \$1M pledge brings relief, attention to suffering Palestinians

Associated Press
NEW YORK

For the Palestinian relief non-profits behind a \$1 million pledge from rapper Macklemore, the Grammy winner’s latest contributions offer more than just money.

Mr. Macklemore committed to donate his net earnings from Ed Sheeran’s Loop Tour after he was dropped for making pro-Palestinian comments on stage at New Jersey’s MetLife Stadium. The goal, he wrote in a Wednesday post on social media, was to “bring the conversation back to where it belongs” – the Palestinian people – after a 48-hour period that



Macklemore performs at the Goldencoast Rap Festival in Corcelles-les-Monts, central-eastern France, on August 30. AFP

saw four supporting acts quit in solidarity and confusion over who held responsibility for the decision.

The six donation recipients included Medical Aid for Palestinians, Pales-

tine Children’s Relief Fund and the U.N. agency for Palestinian refugees, UNRWA. In addition to the funding windfall, their leaders welcomed the renewed public awareness of the perilous living condi-

tions faced by the Palestinian people they treat regularly.

“Even if you don’t see bombs falling every night, the rubble is still there,” said Alicia Phillips Mandaville, the acting CEO of Anera, another beneficiary. “And the traumatized children are still traumatized.”

Tareq Hailat, the director of strategic engagement at Palestine Children’s Relief Fund, said his phone rings “all the time” with calls from people in Gaza “bleeding and asking for help.”

Israeli operations have killed more than 1,000 Palestinians since a fragile ceasefire took effect last October.

Tense border



Crisis alert: Spaniards march to the Moroccan border on Sunday, during a protest over the migration crisis in Ceuta. Locals were marching under the banner ‘SOS Ceuta invadida’ (SOS Ceuta invaded), to protest the recent mass influx of migrants from Morocco. REUTERS

Once a caustic critic of China, Trump is now rolling out the red carpet for Xi

NEWS ANALYSIS

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

When President Donald Trump first ran for office, he called out China as a menace to the U.S. economy, saying it had gutted America’s factories and eroded the middle class.

That tough talk helped Mr. Trump get to the White House a decade ago, but since then, he increasingly speaks in glowing terms about Chinese President Xi Jinping, the geopolitical rival Mr. Trump will fete on Thursday with a state dinner.

“He’s a great gentleman; we get along great,” Mr. Trump said this month. “We have a very good trading relationship and, you know, they’re a competitor and all of that, but we have a very good relationship

with President Xi.”

On issue after issue, the Republican President has given Mr. Xi a pass.

Mr. Trump shrugged off reports that China had provided Iran with satellite imagery, saying, “I think he’s behaved reasonably well.” After accusing Beijing of accessing U.S. voter files back in 2020, Mr. Trump indicated he was hesitant to retaliate: “I think China is maybe a little bit different today than it was then.”

Mr. Trump’s magnanimity comes as China and the United States are in a contest for global leadership, with some of America’s traditional allies rethinking their strategies. China has expanded its dominance in manufacturing and pushed into new technologies such as artificial intelligence and electric vehicles that create risks for the economies of the U.S., Ger-

many, Italy, France, South Korea and Japan, among others.

Unable to change Chinese behaviour, Mr. Trump has resorted to hospitality.

He travelled to Beijing in May, and the two leaders could meet again two more times this year at international summits. Mr. Trump has readied a helipad on the White House South Lawn before Mr. Xi’s arrival and has lamented that his ballroom will not be ready to host the Chinese leader.

‘Dramatic shift’

Mr. Trump has insisted that the U.S. is comfortably ahead of China, but his efforts last year to confront China with a mounting set of tariffs backfired. China holds a relative monopoly on the rare earths used in electronics and deployed that to help force a trade armistice with Mr. Trump.



Cordial ties: A file photo of Xi Jinping greeting Donald Trump at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing on May 14. AP

“Trump has dramatically shifted his approach to China because his initial attempt to use super-high tariffs and export restrictions was unsuccessful,” said Michael Kovrig, a senior adviser at the International Crisis Group. “Xi and Trump got into a contest of leverage, and Xi came out on top.”

Meanwhile, Mr. Trump has largely undermined

the economic and national security alliances that could previously apply pressure on China, said Mr. Kovrig, a former Canadian diplomat who was detained by China during Mr. Trump’s first term.

Mr. Trump has mocked French President Emmanuel Macron in speeches. He has run hot and cold on NATO after several of its members did not fully sup-

port his choice to start a war with Iran. Mr. Trump has launched a potentially brutal trade fight with Canada, a long-time ally he has trolled as becoming the 51st American state.

“He’s executing Xi’s wedge tactics for him, and along the way, helping Xi to tell a story about China as the more stable and responsible power,” Mr. Kovrig said. “It’s led to a wave of Western leaders visiting Beijing and seeking to stabilize and improve their relations with Xi so they can focus more on dealing with problems Trump is causing them.”

Mr. Trump can point to some symbolic wins from having a pleasant relationship with Mr. Xi.

Mr. Trump’s continued tariffs on China have not curbed its manufacturing sector. China has found new markets and boxed out competition from oth-

er industrialised countries. China is exporting more of its goods to the rest of the world with a \$1.2 trillion global trade surplus last year as its low-priced EVs undercut the auto sectors in Germany, Japan and South Korea.

AI race

Both China and the U.S. are using their trade truce to retrench. China is building up its military and AI capabilities despite limited access to advanced computer chips. The Trump administration has pursued partnerships to develop rare earths.

Mr. Trump is also banking on America going full throttle on AI development despite voter resistance to data centres and recent alarming safety warnings from the leading AI companies.

But China has also been accused of having its AI

companies train on U.S. models, a problem for Mr. Trump and the economy if AI is the key to global dominance.

Still, Attorney General Todd Blanche told reporters at the White House last week that it’s “unfair to just label China as a country” as being a “bad actor” on AI.

Asked if Mr. Trump would bring up the issue with Mr. Xi, Mr. Blanche said, “Those two presidents have a great relationship. ... They get along, they make deals together.”

Usually, state visits come with “deliverables” on policy or trade. It’s not yet clear what Thursday’s visit will bring, and it’s possible that the main deliverable will be the relationship itself, rather than clear and measurable goals, said Evan Medeiros, a professor at Georgetown University.

INBRIEF



Niki's all-round show powers India-A past Australia-A

Niki Prasad, *in pic.*, starred with the ball and bat (three for 28 and 32 n.o.) as India-A defeated Australia-A by four wickets in the first one-dayer at Mohali on Sunday. Put in to bat, the visiting side was bowled out for 235 in the 47th over. Tejal Hasabnis made 81 and Anushka Sharma scored 55 as the host romped home with 53 balls to spare to go one up in the three-match series.

The scores: Australia-A 235 in 46.3 overs (Tahila Wilson 48, Vaishnavi Sharma 3/40, Niki Prasad 3/28) lost to India-A 239/6 in 41.1 overs (Tejal Hasabnis 81, Anushka Sharma 55). **Toss:** India-A.

Sambdula bags two races in F4 second round

Goa Aces JA Racing's Luviwe Sambudla won two races in second round of the F4 Indian championship, part of the Indian Racing Festival, at the Kari Motor Speedway in Coimbatore on Sunday. Hyderabad Blackbirds' Bhuvan Bonu was the other winner coming out on top in the reverse-grid race. Kichcha's Kings Aris Kyriakou retained the championship lead after securing three podium finishes across the weekend, while Sambudla's two victories moved him closer to the top of the standings.

Fleming says 'wrong' to ask Stokes to end retirement

Newly appointed England Test coach Stephen Fleming says it would be "wrong" to ask former captain Ben Stokes to reverse his international retirement before next year's Ashes. "He seemed to be really at peace with his decision. To try to turn that around and question that is wrong".

Powar lends Australia under-19 spinners a hand

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

Former India off-spinner Ramesh Powar has joined the Australia u-19 team, helping out its young spinners. Powar joined the squad on Sunday and will spend four days with the team, including Wednesday's final youth ODI against India.

"The Australian team management approached me quite a few months back to come and spend some time with the young spinners and guide them, so I decided to spend four days with them," Powar told *The Hindu*. "It's a one-off gig, and just a short one to guide the young bowlers," he said.

Powar, a former India women's head coach, is al-



Powar. SHAYAN ACHARYA



It's a one-off gig, and just a short one to guide the young bowlers

so tipped to become the next chairman of the National junior selection committee.

Polish women make a habit of beating India

Vaishali's loss to Maltsevskaya on the second board proves vital as the defending champion goes down 1.5-2.5; Praggn and Gukesh's wins do it for the titlist in the fifth round of the open section

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

History repeated itself at the Chess Olympiad on Sunday.

Poland defeated the top-seeded India in the women's event 2.5-1.5 at Samarkand; it was the exact scoreline in Budapest two years ago. That loss had come in the eighth round. India, however, bounced strongly back to win the title. This time around, it happened in the fifth round, and the defeat is indeed a setback to the defending champion.

After the games involving Koneru Humpy, Divya Deshmukh and Vantika Agrawal were all drawn, the fate of the match rested on the second-board clash between R. Vaishali and Aleksandra Maltsevskaya. The Chennai Grandmaster, with black pieces, was three pawns down when she resigned on the 57th move.

Vaishali's younger brother R. Praggnanandhaa, however, scored an important win for India in the open section. He defeated Anish Giri, as the reigning champion won the match against the Netherlands 3-1.

D. Gukesh also won, while there were draws for Arjun Erigaisi and Nihal Sarin. The open event also



Crucial result: Praggnanandhaa held his own against the Netherlands' Anish. FIDE



In the zone: Gukesh is a picture of concentration. FIDE

saw Germany pull off a shocking 2.5-1.5 win over top-seeded United States.

Important results (fifth

round):

Open: India bt Netherlands 3-1 (R. Praggnanandhaa bt Anish Giri; Arjun Erigaisi drew with Jorden van Foreest; Nihal Sarin drew

with Loek van Wely; D. Gukesh bt Erwin L'Ami).
Uzbekistan bt Hungary 4-0; Germany bt USA 2.5-1.5; Armenia drew with China 2-2.

France bt Czechia 2.5-1.5; England bt Georgia 2.5-1.5; Iran bt Lithuania 3-1; Ukraine bt Montenegro 3.5-0.5; Turkiye bt Latvia 3.5-0.5; Serbia bt Cuba 3-1; Poland bt Vietnam 2.5-1.5.

Women: Poland bt India 2.5-1.5 (Koneru Humpy drew with Oliwia Kiolbasa; R. Vaishali lost to Aleksandra Maltsevskaya; Divya Deshmukh drew with Klaudia Kulon, Vantika Agrawal drew with Socko Monika).

USA drew with Uzbekistan 2-2; Kazakhstan bt Germany 2.5-1.5. China bt Bulgaria 3-1; Azerbaijan bt Serbia 3-1; Netherlands drew with Switzerland 2-2; Georgia bt Indonesia 2.5-1.5.

Ukraine bt Austria 2.5-1.5; France bt Slovakia 3-1; Mongolia bt Croatia 2.5-1.5.

Armenia bt Peru 3-1; Hungary bt Brazil 3-1.

Manal bounces back after failing to make it to under-19 WC team

YOUTH ODI SERIES

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

Manal Chauhan started playing cricket for a simple reason – he wanted to bunk school.

He would tell his parents he was going to school and head off to play cricket instead.

"At that time, I was not that interested in the sport, but I kept playing," Manal told *The Hindu* ahead of Monday's second youth ODI between India under-19 and the Australian colts here.

"Gradually, I realised that there were age-group divisions and that you move forward through them and then play for the State. I became very interested in it, so I started giv-



Simple plan: Manal is taking it one step at a time. SHAYAN ACHARYA

ing it my full time."

The boy from Morena has since led Madhya Pradesh to its maiden Cooch Behar Trophy title and made his India u-19 debut on the Sri Lanka tour, scoring 150 and an unbeaten 51 in the second youth Test.

But it wasn't a smooth ride. After a decent Vinoo Mankad Trophy campaign, the all-rounder missed out on the u-19 World Cup.

"I was very demotivated because I wanted to play the World Cup. At that time, I did not know that

there would be further bilateral series like this," he said. His parents and coaches told him there would be more opportunities. "I thought that, at least, I would win the red-ball tournament for MP. I did not know that I would come this far from there."

Madhya Pradesh did win the Cooch Behar Trophy. Then came the India call-up. "The biggest learning has been that things will keep going up and down in life, but you have to stick to your work ethic," he said.

Chandrakant Pandit has helped him work on the mental side of the game, while India u-19 coach Yere Goud taught him to forget mistakes and move on.

Manal is doing just that, taking it one step at a time.

Match starts at 9 a.m.

I couldn't process what was happening: Neeraj on his injury



Unfortunate: Neeraj's ligament injury ruled him out of the Asian Games. FILE PHOTO

ATHLETICS

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India's star javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra termed his absence from the Asian Games unfortunate but said it was important to "accept" the setback and focus on making a quick comeback. The 28-year-old missed out on a chance to complete a hat-trick of Asian Games gold medals after suffering a ligament injury while training.

The injury came soon after Neeraj produced a season-best throw of 88.05m at the Lausanne Diamond League, bringing his 2026 competitive season to an early end.

"It is definitely difficult. I wouldn't say it is easy," he said on the *KheLo Bharat Podcast* of the Sports Authority of India (SAI).

"It has become a little normal for me because this has happened quite a few times in my career. There have been times when I was very well prepared and suddenly suffered an injury.

"Even after winning many things, you still feel that if you had been able to use that time without the injury, perhaps even better things could have happened."

Neeraj said the latest injury was particularly frustrating because he felt he had finally returned to his best after recovering from an earlier setback.

"When I felt that I was finally back to being the old Neeraj again, with the same enthusiasm and consistency, I threw 88 metres. Then, just a day later, I got injured again during training. The first few minutes were very difficult for me. I couldn't process what was happening," he said.

Asked what he would tell Indian athletes competing at the Asian Games, Neeraj urged them to make the most of a rare opportunity.

"I would simply tell them to give their best. You get opportunities like the Games once every four years, so don't leave with anything in your mind that makes you feel later, 'I could have done this,'" he said.



Star performer: Savitha Shri has been on fire at the Olympiad, winning four successive games. FIDE

I approach Vaishali whenever I have a doubt: Savitha Shri

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

She was a wisp of a girl when she faced Magnus Carlsen in a simultaneous display ahead of the Norwegian's World championship match against Viswanathan Anand in the city back in 2013.

B. Savitha Shri has come a long way since and is currently among the top Indian women chess players. A bronze medallist at the World Rapid championship in 2022, the 19-year-old WGM is making the right moves at the ongoing Olympiad in Samarkand.

She has been the star performer, winning all four games on the fourth board before being rested for Sunday's fifth-round match against Poland.

The Chennai player, who trains under R.B. Ramesh, said the coach had been a great support and helped her make giant strides. "He (Ramesh sir)

analyses games and offers psychological support. We work a lot on the middle and end-game," Savitha Shri had told *The Hindu*.

On his part, Ramesh said, "Over the board, she does the most practical things without much hesitation when most players would hesitate."

The work put in with the acclaimed coach appears to be paying off at the Olympiad, and there is no one happier than her father Krishnan Baskar.

The teenager said World championship challenger R. Vaishali was like an "elder sister" and was always ready to help. "I approach Vaishali *akka* whenever I have any doubt. She gives me advice and I look up to her."

Having matched wits with someone who would go on to become one of the greatest-ever, Savitha Shri is now holding her own against the game's elite as she aims for the sky.

Barca purrs along smoothly; City goes top after a thriller



On fire: Raphinha nets Barcelona's third to complete the rout. REUTERS

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
SEVILLE

Raphinha scored a superb hat-trick to earn Barcelona a 3-1 win at Sevilla on Saturday in LaLiga and preserve its 100% record.

The Spanish champion was given the biggest test of its season to date but overcame Sevilla at the Ramon Sanchez-Pizjuan thanks to Raphinha's treble.

LaLiga's top goalscorer, Raphinha reached 12 goals in seven league appearances with a second consecutive hat-trick.

Atletico beats Real

Later on Sunday, Atletico Madrid edged 10-man Real Madrid 2-1 in the Madrid derby to leave Jose Mourinho's side trailing leader Barcelona by six points.

Dean Huijsen was sent off early in the second half for *Los Blancos* before Alejandro Grimaldo and Jonathan David's goals gave Diego Simeone's Atletico victory, with Antonio Rudiger pulling one back late on. Atletico rose to second, five points behind Barca and one ahead of Real Madrid, which chalked up a second defeat of the campaign.

Manchester City went top of the Premier League despite Brian Brobbey's hat-trick in a 5-3 thriller on Sunday as Matheus Cunha rescued Manchester United from another damaging defeat at Fulham with a 1-1 draw.

The results: Premier League: Bournemouth 0 lost to Liverpool 1 (Isak 57); Leeds 0 drew with Crystal Palace 0; Manchester City 5 (Fernandez 9, Cherki 29, Semenyo 43, 57, Haaland 81) bt Sunderland 3 (Brobbey 12, 33, 59); Fulham 1 (Martinez 63-og) drew with Manchester United 1 (Cunha 89).
LaLiga: Atletico Madrid 2 (Grimaldo 53-pen, David 59) bt Real Madrid 1 (Rudiger 89).
Serie A: Fiorentina 1 (Jimenez 51) drew with Napoli 1 (Gilmour 23).
Bundesliga: Bayer Leverkusen 2 (Schick 44, Gutterer 57) bt RB Leipzig 0.

On Saturday: Premier League: Nottingham Forest 0 lost to Coventry 1 (Dasilva 55).

LaLiga: Osasuna 1 (Budimir 16) drew with Rayo Vallecano 0 (Camello 50); Athletic Bilbao 0 drew with Alaves 0; Celta Vigo 5 (Gonzalez 32-pen, Moriba 43, Roman 69, Duran 78, 90+2) bt Racing Santander 0; Sevilla 1 (Fofana 19) lost to Barcelona 3 (Raphinha 22, 52, 69).

Serie A: Bologna 1 (Bernardeschi 14) drew with Torino 1 (Kulenovic 77); Udinese 0 lost to Cagliari 1 (Maldini 54); Roma 2 (Kone 6, 37) drew with Inter Milan 2 (Martinez 46, 79).

Bundesliga: Stuttgart 0 lost to Borussia Dortmund 1 (Beier 70).

Abhishek’s Zen state — India’s pride, world’s envy

The 26-year-old has burst forth as a modern-day six-hitting behemoth against whom the margin for error is miniscule and to whom clearing the boundary is child’s play



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

R. Kaushik

In an era where opening the batting in Test cricket revolved around giving the first hour, if not the first session, to the bowlers, K. Srikanth was a glorious exception to the accepted rule. High on risk and therefore a little short on consistency, the maverick from Tamil Nadu was unstoppable when in the mood, treating the best fast bowlers in the world with utter disdain. Mark Greatbatch at the 1992 World Cup, and Sanath Jayasuriya in 1996, are often eulogised for changing the face of opening the batting, but long before these two left-handers left their mark, Srikanth had made hitting over the top fashionable. With complete and utter disregard for reputations, and with a nonchalance that comes only to the chosen few. Strategies chalked at team meetings, he was told, need not concern him. First Sunil Gavaskar, and then Kapil Dev, encouraged Srikanth to be himself, to bat with natural flair and flamboyance. No one expected him to bat like Gavaskar, studied in defence and treating each ball

assiduously on its merit because, well, he wouldn’t be Srikanth then, would he? And so, the right-hander went on a rampage whenever he could.

Not an accurate picture
A Test average of 29.88 from 43 matches, and a 50-over international average of 29.01 spread across 145 innings, do not paint an accurate picture of the potential for mayhem that he possessed. Srikanth was a lot more than the sum of his six international hundreds and the highest individual tally in a low-scoring final of the 1983 World Cup, because the entertainment he provided and the value he brought with him to the batting crease were beyond parallel in that time and age. Srikanth was a pioneer, without question, his brand of batsmanship unique and remarkably enviable in his time in international cricket. The subsequent emergence of a host of destructive openers, among them a certain Sachin Tendulkar who was thrust into the role of an ODI opener almost accidentally in 1994 and who went on to finish with 49 international tons in the 50-over version, is a back-handed

compliment to the Srikanth school of aggression that has gained immense currency in the last two and a quarter decades, from the time the 20-over iteration stormed cricketing consciousness. Virender Sehwag and Chris Gayle made a name for themselves by beautifully fusing untold havoc with stunning consistency. Both openers, the former converted from a middle-order practitioner, signed off with two Test triple tons apiece - with only the great Don Bradman and Brian Lara for company in that exclusive club of four - to reiterate that aggressive batting need not be at the expense of sustained masterpieces. Having grown up watching the deeds of these two stalwarts, among others, Abhishek Sharma has now burst forth as a modern-day six-hitting behemoth against whom the margin for error is miniscule and to whom clearing the boundary boards is little more than child’s play. Abhishek is now 26, still some way short of hitting his peak as a batter. Internationally, he figures in only one format and it is only a matter of time before he is allowed to spread his wings and dot the 50-over landscape too with spectacular edifices. But even in that one limited-overs format, he has showcased a penchant for the bold and the beautiful that is impossible to miss. Numerous batters who have failed to tickle the scorers in their first international innings have had a stellar career, not least the legendary G.R. Vishwanath, who followed up nought in the first innings of his debut Test against Australia in Kanpur in 1969 with 137 of the best in the second dig. Abhishek’s international career too got off to the most inauspicious of beginnings - he fell for a second-ball duck against Zimbabwe in Harare in July 2024 - but the very next day, he made the world sit up and take notice by smashing a 47-ball century against the same opponents, now thoroughly shell-shocked. It was evident even at that early stage that this was a special talent that needed to be encouraged rather than fettered, that was best left to its own devices so that he could learn from his mistakes and polish the rough edges instead of being instructed to redefine his high-risk approach. Abhishek took some time in striking the right balance between all-out attack and judiciousness in shot-selection, but once he found the magic formula, he has been an unstoppable force at the highest level. Abhishek has played 58 T20I innings, which is a fairly reasonable sample size. Despite taking the fight to the bowlers, he has blasted three hundreds and 12 half-centuries. Despite his propensity to hit the ball in the air, he averages 33.17. And because he loves dismantling attacks and bruising egos, he has been able to strike at an extraordinary 194.55, laced with 182 fours and 126 sixes. Every year since its inception, the Indian Premier League rewards the highest scorer of the season with the Orange Cap. In so many ways, that is incongruous because T20 cricket is seldom about quantum. It is about impact, it’s about the value of the runs made. Given that eight-ball 25s are seen as being more crucial than 35-ball half-centuries, strike-rate would appear to be a logical route to deciding the significance of a batter to his team’s fortunes, but strike-rate alone can’t be the criterion if it rewards only cameos and disregards more meaningful contributions. Various quarters have advocated using average and strike-rate in tandem to decide the worth of a batter. The former is a marker of consistency, the latter a pointer to explosiveness. In Abhishek’s case, combining the average and the strike-rate in T20Is will give him a whopping total of 227.72. Now, while that is just a number, it is a more accurate reflection of the kind of havoc he can wreak. Abhishek’s latest epic came on Thursday night at the National capital’s Arun Jaitley Stadium. In the last of three T20Is that Afghanistan hosted against India in India last Thursday, Abhishek’s most unforgiving avatar was on full view. In a mere 30 deliveries, he raced to his third T20I century, a good 19 months after his previous ton, against England in Mumbai in February 2025. The hundred included nine fours and 10 sixes - 96% of his runs came in boundaries - and by the time he was dismissed, he had added one more six in his final score of 108, off a ridiculous 34 balls. It is the fastest T20I hundred against a full-member nation, the fastest ton internationally in the 20-over game by a batter from a full-member country. Quips that Abhishek defeated the Afghans by 14 runs weren’t just cute. They aptly illustrated the full weight of his dominance against a bowling group that is pedestrian by no stretch of the imagination. Afghanistan might be a little undercooked when it comes to batting in the topmost echelons, but as a bowling unit, they hardly suffer in comparison. Rashid Khan, Fazalhaq Farooqi, Mujeeb Ur Rahman and Mohammad Nabi form a formidable quartet, but Abhishek left



Abhishek’s latest epic came at the National capital’s Arun Jaitley Stadium. In the last of three T20Is that Afghanistan hosted against India in India, his most unforgiving avatar was on full view. In a mere 30 deliveries, he raced to his third T20I century, a good 19 months after his previous ton, against England in Mumbai in February 2025

them quivering in their collective boots, waiting for and ruthlessly punishing any indiscretion in length or direction with the most scything, punitive of willows. In the two preceding matches of the series at the same venue, Abhishek had reeled off scores of 82 (32b) and 39 (19b) respectively. His lowest strike-rate (205.26) came in game two, sandwiched between similar efforts of 256.25 and 317.64, the latter killing any competitive interest in the dead rubber just a quarter of the way into the no-contest. It was Abhishek at his majestic best, unhurried and unflustered, using a strong base as his ally and carefully eschewing the premeditation that has left many a batter horribly out of position. Abhishek seldom uses exaggerated foot movement whilst waiting for the bowler to deliver the ball, nor does he often seek recourse to the unconventional such as the reverse-scoop or a switch hit. His areas of preference are in front of square rather than behind it. A beautiful bat-swing with the willow on the downward curve can be mesmerising and because Abhishek strikes the ball cleanly and down the ground, it’s more than likely that he will forever be one step ahead of the opposition. The effortlessness with which he sends the ball soaring deep into the stands is audaciously breathtaking in its simplicity and for the debilitating (for the bowlers) outcome from which there is no recovery. The very nature of the T20 beast is such that it is almost an antidote to consistency. The consensus is that opening batters are best placed to stack up all the records, and there is no arguing with that because, after all, they are in a position to play more deliveries than those succeeding them in the batting order. But the propensity to push the envelope manifests itself in greater risk-taking when the field restrictions are in place, which automatically brings with it the threat of courting cheap dismissals. Conservatism has been thrown out of the window a long time back. India are the leaders, in a manner of speaking, in setting the tone, having woken up to the demands of the format a little later than some others, and have now meticulously pieced together an amazing set of destroyers with Abhishek as the primary wrecking ball. The Afghanistan series saw him at his fiercely consistent best. He had a reasonably forgettable T20 World Cup; three ducks at the start were only marginally offset by a blazing half-century in the final, but he seems to have rediscovered his mojo now, which is an excellent sign with the Asian Games gold medal defence now exactly a week away.

Furious competition
Abhishek will be keen to show that there is more to him than just a 20-over marauder. There is furious competition for top-order places in the 50-over setup, with someone like Yashasvi Jaiswal, who has two hundreds in his last three ODI innings, struggling to break through. Abhishek’s List A (domestic 50-over) record isn’t trifling - he averages 33.78 while striking at 100.18 in 68 innings - but while he will be keen to evolve as a multi-format performer, he won’t lose any sleep over his longer-version future. For now, his calling is in T20s and that’s where he will try to maximise his efficacy and get the team off to the kind of starts they have come to take for granted. He won’t be fazed by the fact that Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is breathing down his neck, or that there are other acknowledged ball-bashers aspiring for higher honours. Abhishek has found his Zen state — India’s pride, the rest of the world’s envy.

THE GIST

Abhishek took some time in striking the right balance between all-out attack and judiciousness in shot-selection, but once he found the magic formula, he has been an unstoppable force at the highest level

He has played 58 T20I innings, which is a fairly reasonable sample size. Despite taking the fight to the bowlers, he has blasted three hundreds and 12 half-centuries

Since the southpaw strikes the ball cleanly and down the ground, it’s more than likely that he will forever be one step ahead of the opposition



DELHI



Residents of a JJ cluster in Pul Mitai, part of Chandni Chowk constituency, who received notices from the Election Commission. Many residents said they lacked the prescribed documents required for SIR verification. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

In India’s capital, Delhiites reduced to documents

Across SIR hearing centres in the national capital, people are making repeated trips, producing documents, and waiting for hours to prove their eligibility, often despite having voted for years. **Ishita Mishra** and **Suruchi Kumari** spoke to people appealing to retain their right to vote and officials who share the reality of a process marked by confusion. As always, the burden to prove their identity is falling hardest on society’s poorer, less-documented voter

Adhaar number. PAN card. Voter ID. Ration card. Sanichari Devi, 63, has packed all of these documents into a polythene bag for the special intensive revision (SIR) hearing at the Government Sarvodaya Bal Vidyalaya, a government school near Mori Gate in Delhi’s Chandni Chowk Assembly constituency on September 15.

These were the papers by which the state had recognised her, again and again, as a citizen all these years, she claims. But that afternoon they were not enough.

“First, the official at the hearing asked me to bring a bank passbook for which I had to return home,” she says. Home is about two kilometres away in an overcrowded Chandni Chowk locality. “When I came back panting, I was again sent another kilometre to get a photocopy of the documents,” she says on this errand alone.

“*Tum log hai na padha likha toh bhi nahi bujha raha hai ki ka ka chahiye, hum toh hain hi angootha chaap*, (You are all educated; even then you’re not telling us clearly what documents are needed. I am unlettered),” she says, distressed by the officials’ impatience and their cryptic responses.

For nearly two hours, Devi, who claims her name was on the 2002 electoral roll in Bihar, where she was born, clutches her papers trying to understand the process of staying on India’s electoral roll. She is surrounded by 70 to 80 people, all with similar problems.

Devi is a daily-wage earner. Her ₹400-500 for the day is lost and she has no idea how to pay for her family of three, including two grandsons. Her son and daughter-in-law are no more. Exhausted from walking and distressed from losing a day’s wage, Devi faints in the afternoon sun. Two men catch her before she falls and help her to a chair.

The government school in Chandni Chowk is one of the three locations in this Assembly constituency where SIR hearings are taking place. These hearings are for voters who had notices served to them for anomalies, like name mismatches, and for being unmapped – meaning their names or relatives’ names were not found on older SIR rolls.

At every hearing location, 100 to 1,000 people turn up every day with documents to prove that they are eligible to vote. Once they are there, many find that none of their documents match the 11 ID proofs prescribed by the Election Commission of India for the SIR. The exercise, rolled out in 2025 just before the Bihar Assembly election, was intended to clean up voter lists by identifying duplicate entries and removing the names of those who have died, moved from their addresses, or are illegal migrants. But since it was rolled out, and now having covered 30 of India’s States and Union Territories, over 13 crore people on the voter list have been removed during the draft stage. This has become the subject of intense public debate, with concerns that genuine voters are being left out, particularly those who struggle

They want illiterate people like us to provide such minute details that date back to 2002, while officials themselves are so careless that they sent me a notice for September 14, despite the fact that there was a UPSC and NDA entrance exam at this centre. If they cannot keep an account of a month’s calendar, how are we supposed to keep everything in place for years?

RAM CHANDAR
Housekeeping worker

to navigate a documentation-heavy process. The scale of deletions has been striking in Delhi. Of 1.45 crore people who were on the rolls on June 16, 2026, only 97.5 lakh remain. Around 47.6 lakh people have been marked Absent, Shifted, Dead, and Duplicate (ASDD) as reasons for their exclusion at the draft stage. Of the 97.5 lakh on the list, more than one-third on the draft rolls face notices. These will be disposed of by October 29 after they submit their documents either online or at the hearing centres. The final roll will be published on November 4.

Physical and mental stress

At an SIR hearing centre in Rajouri Garden’s government boys’ school, the queue snakes past five rows of Booth Level Officers (BLOs) and Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs) seated at desks with laptops. Each family in the line carries a folder of documents collected over decades. Every day, around 500 cases are scheduled for hearing here.

Ram Chandar, 55, from Etah in Uttar Pradesh, has lived in Delhi for 37 years, working at a housekeeping service. He says he has voted during the tenures of Sheila Dikshit and Arvind Kejriwal, and in the last election when Rekha Gupta came to power. But this time, all his family members, including his parents, wife, brother, and sister-in-law, received notices stating that they had failed to provide details of themselves or a relative from the 2002 SIR rolls.

He is among more than 13.79 lakh people who have been served notices in Delhi after being marked “unmapped”; another 19.33 lakh were flagged for “logical discrepancies”, including

name mismatches and age-related anomalies. Even after submitting his previous voter ID, his identification could not be established.

“They want illiterate people like us to provide such minute details that date back to 2002, while officials themselves are so careless that they sent me a notice for September 14, despite the fact that there was a UPSC and NDA entrance exam at this centre. If they cannot keep an account of a month’s calendar, how are we supposed to keep everything in place for years?” he says. His mother and sister-in-law, he says, would not be able to attend the hearing as they were in the village for a family function. “Will their names be deleted forever?” he wonders.

After a three-hour wait, when he climbs onto the stage where officials sit, the BLO takes barely a minute to answer his queries, and sends him back with a list of additional documents to bring.

A few places behind him, Seema (name changed to protect privacy), 31, is helping her husband Rahul (name changed to protect privacy) navigate the same scrutiny. “*Waise to tum logon ko unke kapdon se pehchaan lete hain; ab humein nahi pehchaan rahe ki hum tumhare desh ke hain ki nahi?* (You can recognise people by their clothes, but now you can’t even recognise whether we belong to your country or not?),” she asks.

In 2019, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had said at a rally in Jharkhand (amid protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act, which was passed that year) that people could identify “*aag lagane wale* (arsonists)” by their clothes. In Rahul’s case, the only discrepancy was that his father’s name Mahavir was spelled “Mahaveer” on his voter ID. “They asked me to get this corrected and appeal for another hearing,” he says. If Ram Chandar and Rahul were undone by mismatched records, others were undone by the process itself.

Preeti Bora Mondal, 44, received a physical notice for a hearing on September 12, but missed it because of an official event scheduled a month earlier. “Now I got a notice over the phone for October 7. The notice reads that if I have any query, I can contact my BLO. But when I did, she never picked up,” she says. She adds, “They are serving us these notices as if we are criminals or have done something wrong.”

Most recipients didn’t know they could submit their documents online. The website link is available via a QR code on the notice.

Paramjeet Thukral, 55, who has recently moved to her parents’ home in Tagore Garden from south Delhi, says she did try to do everything online, but was unsuccessful as the system said she didn’t have the right documents. “I had attached everything which was needed,” she says, adding that if even half the time the government was spending on the exercise had gone into the city instead, “the roads would be better and the city cleaner.”



Voters who received notices to prove their eligibility in the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) queue at a designated centre with documents in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Manoj (name changed to protect privacy) and his family of five, who were also at the centre to respond to a notice, had received assurance that their enrolments would stand. His 80-year-old grandmother didn’t get this assurance, despite having voted in at least 10 State and Central elections. “So many illegal votes are cast in every election; they are not vigilant at that time,” he says. Seema, still nearby, is less measured: “*Agli baar aane do inko vote maangne, tab bataayenge* (The next time let them come asking for our votes; then we’ll teach them a lesson).” She is furious at the two-day wage loss her husband has suffered to get their names enrolled in the voter list and is worried about the cost of the Internet café and corrections still ahead of them.

The confusion around documents

The AERO, Prabhas Kumar, who is attending to queries alone at Devi’s centre, says 7,000 notices had been generated at the centre comprising 50 booths of Chandni Chowk and BLOs are on the field to serve these notices to the people.

On the day Devi visited his station, he said that none of the people had the required documents. “But we are not turning them away. We are taking whatever they are bringing, from a Class 5 marksheet to a discharge card from the hospital where they were born,” Prabhas said, adding that even after maximum consideration, at least 50 people are turned away every day because they do not have a single valid document.

As per the EC’s Standard Operating Procedure for the SIR, submitting only Aadhaar as a document is not sufficient.

Even though the 11 documents include educational certificates, this did not solve the problem for Yashoda Devi, 36. She sat restless outside the hall after being told that her Class 12 certificate, which she had spent a day looking for, would not be accepted because it did not mention her date of birth.

“I only have this. I don’t have a passport or a house in my name. My Class 10 certificate was destroyed when my parents’ house in Varanasi caught fire,” she says. Prabhas says a bank passbook could be attached for date of birth proof, but he is unsure if it will be accepted.

In Rajouri Garden, several people say they are being asked to provide PAN cards. “I had my Class 10 CBSE marksheet and passport for age proof, yet the BLO kept insisting on a PAN card. When I resisted, saying it was not in the list of 11 documents shared with us, he took the marksheet,” says an attendee at the centre who did not wish to be named.

Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) Iti Agarwal, however, refuted that PAN was being forced on people. “We are taking the PAN card as an additional document for proof of date of birth in cases where the elector has brought no document from those listed by the EC, or where the document provided is unsatisfactory. It is not mandatory since it is not a listed document,” she says. Even though hearings are scheduled in three time slots from the morning to 5 p.m., people in early slots end up waiting until the evening due to the lack of documents and some returning without a chance of hearing in a given slot. Their hearings are rescheduled.

Ader Khan, 52, has come directly from his daily-wage job in Wazirpur after taking half a day off with his wife Heena Khan for their 3-5 p.m. slot. However, when they asked for a token, they were turned away and told to come the next day or wait until 7.30 p.m.

“On one day, there are 300 people scheduled to attend a hearing. Not all show up. Of those who do, the desk is able to process only 120-130 cases due to paucity of time,” says Kumar. As people surround the desk with their doubts, Kumar yells at a BLO who isn’t working at the centre but came for her own hearing. “You yourself don’t know what you have to do. It is because of this that so many people have been served notices. If BLOs had done their job properly, then all these people wouldn’t be standing here with their notices today.”

A BLO from North-east Delhi says the training was minimal and women, who have been appointed as teachers and now must do this work, are expected to go door to door. “How do you expect a woman to knock on a door when the smell of liquor reaches you even before the door is opened?” she says.

In west Delhi, a BLO complains that people living in *kothis* (bungalows) do not open their doors for them. She says she has sacrificed her brother’s wedding because of her work and leaves her newborn at home until 6 p.m. every day. “We serve notices through WhatsApp in that case,” she adds.

Digital rights activist Nikhil Pahwa, who was also served an SIR notice, says his experience at a hearing centre in central Delhi raises concerns over consent, communication, and the burden placed on voters.

“Officials directed applicants to write their mobile phone numbers on forms despite these being optional, raising questions about whether voter IDs were being linked to phone numbers without the voters’ consent. Also, whether consent was taken for photographing the voters,” he says, adding that he plans to file an RTI on the issue.

He adds that officials are rude, almost bullying people from underprivileged sections of society. At Rajouri Garden, an official yells at a woman wearing a salwar suit when she climbs onto the stage to ask when she would be called. She has been waiting for hours. “Get down, or I will lodge an FIR against you,” the official says, leaving the woman humiliated enough to leave the hearing.

ishita.mishra@thehindu.co.in
suruchi.kumari@thehindu.co.in

TAMIL NADU

A stone cold
PERPETRATOR

An influential industrialist now finds himself at the centre of a widening investigation under the POCSO Act into the allegations of paedophilia. While he was under investigation from last year, a fresh probe, ordered by the court, led the police to recover additional digital evidence and identify multiple victims. **R. Sivaraman** examines what has been labelled the ‘Epstein case of Tamil Nadu’, only to discover that while the scale of operations was nowhere near that of the American offender, a subterranean network of sexual abusers and their enablers did operate for years

For decades, R. Veeramani, 84, known as ‘Gem Granite’ Veeramani, was celebrated as one of the architects of India’s granite industry. He helped build the sector’s institutional framework, headed industry bodies, and was honoured by the Union government for his contribution to granite mining and marketing. He was also known for his philanthropic activities.

Veeramani, a lawyer, entered the natural stone industry by chance and went on to become one of its pioneers. He built a multi-core business and carefully cultivated a social circle that included politicians, celebrities, and other public figures. There seemed to have been another side to him though. Today, the Greater Chennai Police are investigating charges that he has sexually assaulted minor girls. The case took a dramatic turn after a Special Court for POCSO Act cases last month rejected an earlier police report seeking to close the investigation and ordered further inquiries.

Origin of the case

The case originated with a complaint filed by a child rights activist of an NGO based at Anna Nagar, Chennai, with the Inspector of the Immoral Traffic Prevention Unit (ITPU) on October 6, 2025.

The complaint was forwarded by the then Additional Commissioner of the Central Crime Branch (CCB) for further action. The following day, the CCB registered a case under Sections 7 and 8 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and it was forwarded to the Assistant Commissioner of the ITPU on October 9.

According to the complaint, while the activist was at her office, an unidentified person handed over a cover containing a message and a pen drive. A man (later identified as Veeramani) was seen hugging a minor girl, touching her inappropriately, and sexually abusing her on a bed at a house belonging to Shanthi, described as his associate.

The police officer who initially investigated the case found that a search of the house mentioned in the complaint or shown in the video reportedly did not yield any evidence of wrongdoing on the part of persons named in the complaint.

On February 20, 2026, the Assistant Commissioner, ITPU, filed a report before the court recommending that further action be dropped. According to the report, the video appeared to show an incident that had taken place in 2019.

The police examined a digital video recorder (DVR) from the suspected location with the assistance of an authorised cyber-forensic expert. However, the investigators said they could not recover the original recording or any other relevant footage from the device.

The earlier report cited several difficulties, including the police’s inability to identify the girl in the video, the absence of usable CCTV footage, and the lack of statements from Shanthi’s neighbours. It also stated that the cyber-forensic expert could not retrieve the original recording from the DVR because approximately six years had passed since the alleged incident.

During the inquiry, Veeramani and Shanthi were questioned. Veeramani denied that he was the person seen in the video and said he did not know the person who appeared in the footage with a girl who seemed to be a minor. Shanthi, on the other hand, said she knew Veeramani but did not know the girl. She also stated that the location shown in the footage was not part of her house.

The report stated that the age and identity of the person resembling a minor in the video could not be established and there were no grounds to proceed further at that stage. The case was therefore classified as ‘Further Action Dropped’ and the report was submitted to the court. The police added that further action would be taken if new evidence or witnesses emerged.

However, the Special Court rejected the report and ordered further investigation, following which the inquiry was reopened in July 2026. During the fresh inquiry, the police searched Shanthi’s residence at Teynampet and recovered what they described as the original footage of the alleged sexual assault from an electronic device, a letter said to be written by Shanthi, and mobile records. Investigators also found indications of an attempt to destroy evidence. The seized device



We registered the case immediately after receiving the video. There was no laxity in the probe. Since the visuals were unclear, we could not identify the victim. Without identifying the victim, we could not proceed further

A SENIOR POLICE OFFICER

es were sent for forensic examination.

In a statement issued on August 29, the Greater Chennai Police said the person seen in the video stored on the pen drive had been identified as Veeramani. They added that Veeramani had rented a house at Teynampet and entrusted its management to Shanthi and her husband Mahendran Simhan. Investigators alleged that several minor girls had been brought to the house and sexually assaulted. The police also said video evidence relating to one such incident had been seized.

During the searches of the homes and offices of suspected individuals, the police recovered evidence, including photographs of minor girls connected with the incidents. Shanthi, 55, Mahendran Simhan, 60, and Veeramani were arrested and remanded in judicial custody. The police alleged that Shanthi and her husband had assisted in the offences. The investigation continued. A senior police officer said Shanthi’s alleged role could be broadly compared with that of Ghislaine Maxwell (in Jeffrey Epstein’s case), who was convicted for facilitating the sexual abuse of minors.

Victim identified

Last week, the police investigating the POCSO Act case identified the minor girl allegedly assaulted by Veeramani. She was 12 years old at the time of the alleged incident. The survivor’s statement was recorded before a Judicial Magistrate. She identified herself and Veeramani in the video.

The police subsequently traced and identified three more victims, all of whom were aged 12-15 at the time of the incidents. Sources said more victims came forward to record their statements on the assaults by the prime accused after being assured that their identities would be kept secret.

Greater Chennai Police Commissioner A. Amalraj said, “We strictly follow the guidelines while handling such cases. Tracing the victims took time, and the investigation is being conducted in accordance with the procedures prescribed by law. After conducting a thorough investigation, we will file a charge sheet in time and get conviction.”

During the investigation, the police also unearthed the case of suicide of a minor girl in early 2003, linked to Veeramani. Shanthi’s message to Veeramani stated that a child had ended her life because of him.

Minors targeted

A senior police officer said Veeramani had targeted girls aged 12-16 over several years. The officer said he lured children by offering small amounts of money, sports shoes, chocolates, and mobile phones.

Sources said Veeramani encouraged children to enter the premises of his bungalow as he remained in the portico, pretending to play ball. The children used to pick up balls tossed around. He used to give them chocolates and eatables when they entered his premises but targetted only the girls for exploitation. He would pick the targets, ask their names, and give them his phone number, saying that they could approach him for any assistance, including financial help. If they contacted him, he would reportedly send a driver to bring them to the bungalow. He would take them to his bedroom and the victims were then sexually assaulted. He had given them amounts ranging from ₹2,000 to ₹5,000. If a victim complained that it was too low, the payment was increased, in some instances to ₹50,000. Sometimes, he gave the

girls mobile phones or sports shoes. The officer also alleged that Veeramani invited children to parties at hotels, transported them in luxury cars, and then sexually assaulted them. This went on for years.

Back entrance and secret room

Police sources further said the victims had identified the back entrance, the bedroom of his bungalow, and the secret room in his office. An officer also said Shanthi had claimed she was raped by Veeramani when she was 13 and she had a son from him. Police sources said she was seeking a share of Veeramani’s property. They also said Shanthi was trained as an architect and was now running a dance school. She and her husband had served as directors of a company owned by Veeramani and were on his payroll.

When contacted, there was no response from Veeramani’s side to the allegations against him. Police sources said the investigation had only begun and they suspect more revelations would emerge.

Dismissing allegations that the investigation had been subverted last year, a senior officer who had earlier served in the Commissionerate said, “We registered the case immediately after receiving the video. There was no laxity in the investigation. Since the visuals were unclear, we could not identify the victim. Without identifying the victim, we could not proceed further, but we did not close the case. Had we identified the victim, we would have taken the investigation forward.”

It is learnt that a report on the status of the case was filed in February to comply with the prescribed legal time frame. The report did not seek closure of the case. The officer said the case was kept open, with the provision that the investigation could be revived if any fresh evidence emerged.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State’s health helpline 104, Tele-MANAS 14416, and Sneha’s suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050.)



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI



Tracing the victims took time, and the investigation is being conducted in accordance with the procedures prescribed by law. After conducting a thorough investigation, we will file a charge sheet in time and get conviction

A. AMALRAJ,
Greater
Chennai Police
Commissioner